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Amparo's Hands

a novel of Véspera



VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

THE VÉSPERA LIBRARY · SHELF I · THE FAMILY HOUSES

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This is a work of fiction. Véspera, its houses and its people are imagined, and any resemblance to real persons is the resemblance true stories bear to one another. This novel has a self-knowledge sibling: if Amparo hurts you in real places, the name of what she carries is in “The Mother Who Saves”, in the FreeMe Mother collection. A story understands, but it does not replace care: in the deep matters, seek support. You deserve the same care you give.

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From the register of Véspera

*In the record of the House of the Olive Press, in the hand of the
Keepers who have kept the book, the following is found:*

Amparo, of the House of the Olive Press; her name means shelter.

*Born in the year of the Great Winter, sister to Custódia, whose
name means keeping, to Glória, and to Amadeu, who was entered
in this book for the last time many years ago.*

Married to Fortunato, of the lower fields; his name means fortunate. His widow these six winters.

*Mother of Vera, whose name means true, and of Salvo, whose
name means safe. The son's name was a promise: he came into the
world with the cord around his neck and the midwife gave him up
for lost twice. The third time, his mother swore that if he lived, his
name would say forever what he was. Safe.*

*The register says who was born, who married, who departed. It
does not say who carries whom. For that, books such as this one
are needed.*

1. The hands

Amparo's hands woke before she did.

It had been so always, or since an always so old it no longer had a beginning. She would open her eyes in the dark and her hands would already be halfway through the day: they had lit the fire, they had set the water to warm, they knew, before she knew, what needed doing and for whom. Amparo followed them the way one follows two good herding dogs, trusting, asking no questions about the way.

That morning, the hands knew it was a day for the shop.

She left the house with the first light, while the serra was still a shape lying down and the river, below, was more heard than seen. There was no one on the road, which was why she went at that hour. In her coat pocket, folded in four, she carried the month's money, and she carried it as she had always carried it: without counting it in front of anyone, herself included.

The shop opened early for those bound for the fields. Benvinda was at the counter, pencil behind her ear, setting out the bread. When she saw Amparo come in, she lowered her hand slowly and went still, with the stillness of someone who recognises a ceremony.

"Here you are again," she said.

"Here I am again."

Nothing more was needed. Benvinda fetched the ledger of debts from under the counter, opened it at the right letter and pushed it half a hand's width across, only half, like someone not quite willing to hand it over. On the page, in Benvinda's round writing, was Salvo's entire month: the wine, the tobacco, the tinned food, a length of rope, more wine. Amparo read it top to bottom without a change of face. She took the money from her pocket, unfolded it, laid it on the wood.

"Cross it out."

Benvinda did not pick up the money at once. She stood looking at it with an old tiredness that did not belong to that morning.

"I'll cross it out, Amparo. Crossing out I can do." She lowered her voice, though there was no one else in the shop. "But mark one thing, which I've never said to you. Twenty years this ledger has carried your son's handwriting and the money from your hand. The one who owes has never known what it costs. And the one who pays never owed a thing."

"Cross it out," Amparo said again, without hardness. "The rest is not yours and not mine."

Benvinda crossed it out. She crossed it out slowly, line by line, she who had never crossed out anyone's debt in her life, and she was still standing with the pencil in the air when Amparo reached the door. From the street, Amparo heard her say something that might as easily have been goodbye as oh, woman, woman. She did not turn back to settle which.

At home she did what she did. She opened the east-facing windows, fed the hens, set the broth to draw. Halfway through the morning her hands went, by themselves, to the high shelf of the pantry, to the flour tin that held no flour. That was where the other money lived, the reserve, the God-spare-us money. They counted it out on the table, smoothed the notes, set aside what would cover a month's rent. Amparo came to herself with the

envelope already made, and she could have sworn she had never decided to make it. She had known nothing. But the hands knew. The hands always knew first, and what they knew that morning was this: Salvo was coming. No one had told her. No one needed to. For thirty years Amparo had felt her son's falls before her son fell, the way the old women of the serra feel rain in their knees.

The telephone rang at noon. It was Vera.

"Mother."

"Yes, child."

"I've heard. The building work has stopped." A pause the size of a stitch. "Has he been round yet?"

"He's coming."

"Of course he is." Vera took a long breath, and Amparo knew that breath: it was her own, exactly, the breath of someone folding her patience away inside like folding sheets. "Mother, I'm not going to say what I said last time."

"You always say it."

"So I do." And she said it: "One of these days your hands will come down on him with everything they carry, and he won't even feel the weight. Because he never has. To him your hands weigh nothing, Mother. They're like air to him. You are like air to him."

Amparo looked at her hands, lying open on the table beside the envelope. Seen like that, at rest, they were the hands of a woman of sixty-three: the wedding ring buried in the finger since she had put on weight, an old scar from the olive press, the thick knuckles. They did not look capable of coming down on anyone.

"Air is needed too," was what she answered. And she regretted the sentence before it ended, because she heard it in her own mother's mouth, spoken in that same kitchen fifty years before, about another man.

Vera was quiet for a moment.

"It is," she said at last, tired. "Needed by the one who breathes it, Mother. It's you who haven't breathed for a long time now. Give him a kiss from me."

Salvo arrived in the middle of the afternoon, with the light already slanting across the fields. Amparo heard the gate and did not go to the door: she stayed in the kitchen, on purpose, her hands tied one inside the other under her apron, to teach them to wait. He came in the way he always came in, with the shuffle of a man apologising to the floor, and sat down at the corner of the table, in the place that had been his since childhood.

He looked well, at first sight. That was what no one outside the family understood: Salvo always looked well at first sight. He had his father's easy laugh and her eyes, and a way of telling his misfortunes that made the misfortunes sound like jokes, at least for as long as the telling lasted.

"The work's stopped, Mother," he said. "It's nothing, it's the usual. The contractor got himself in trouble with the people from away, so now it's either pay for the materials or pay the men, well, there it is. None of it mine, this time. I was even doing well up there. Ask old Justo, he saw me up on the..."

And he talked, and talked. Amparo warmed his broth, cut him bread, set the plate in front of him, and all of this her hands did for her while she listened, because that was what her hands knew to do with distress: feed it. He ate the way he had eaten as

a boy, quickly and gratefully, talking sideways, and at a certain point, without a change of tone, in the middle of a sentence about the contractor, he let it drop:

"...and then there's the rent, of course, that was due this fortnight, but well, that will sort itself out somehow..."

He did not ask. Salvo never asked. He had a way of laying his wants out on the table, within reach of her hands, and her hands did the rest. It was an understanding so old and so sure that it no longer needed words: he brought the fall, she brought the ground.

And Amparo's hands, under the apron, moved.

It was in that movement, that half-movement towards the envelope sitting right there on the end of the dresser, that the small thing happened from which everything else would come. Amparo saw herself. She never managed to explain it any other way, not that afternoon and not afterwards: she saw herself, as if she were standing in the corner of the kitchen looking at a seated woman, a woman whose hands were already on their way, and at the same time, laid over her, she saw another kitchen just like that one, and another woman, her mother,

reaching into her apron pocket while Amadeu, at the corner of the table, the same corner, told sideways the misfortune that was not his fault, not that time either. The whole village said her mother was a saint. They said it on the church terrace, on the way out, with that respect that is kept for women who spend themselves. A saint. And Amadeu stayed, and stayed, and stayed, and of Amparo's elder brother the village came in the end to say only, and ever more quietly, that he had never had any luck.

Their mother died first. She went while Amadeu was still there, at the corner of the table.

Amparo's hands stopped under the apron.

That was all, that afternoon. Let no one look here for the miracle, the woman who from one day to the next shuts the tin and sets her life straight, because that woman does not exist in Véspera or anywhere else. Amparo got up, fetched the envelope, laid it beside her son's plate. But first she counted it. For the first time in thirty years she counted the money in front of him, note by note, slowly, and Salvo looked away, because counted money has a weight that folded money does not.

"It covers the rent," she said. "This time."

"I know, Mother. As soon as the work starts up again, I'll..."

"Salvo."

He fell silent. She stood there, her hands resting one in the other, still for once, and she asked him the question she had never in her life asked him. It came out simple, without anger, with a small astonishment in her voice, like someone noticing a door that had always been there and never been opened:

"And you. How will you get up, yourself?"

Salvo looked at his mother. He opened his mouth to give the usual answer, and it could be seen that there was no usual answer for this: the question had no reply folded away anywhere in the house. There was a long silence, of a kind that kitchen had not heard in many years, perhaps since the cord around the neck. Outside, the hens. The river below, which never fell entirely quiet.

"I'll manage somehow," he said at last, very low, and it was not an answer, and they both knew it was not.

When he had gone, the light already leaving the fields, Amparo stood at the window watching him go down the path, as she always did. Then she sat at the table, in his place, a thing she never did, and laid her hands open on the wood, palms up, the way of someone asking or someone showing. She looked at them a long time. Her catching hands, her paying hands, her hands for breaking falls. They did not yet know how to be still, and they would move many times yet, and wrongly, and too soon, before they learned.

But they had been noticed. And in Véspera it is known, better than anywhere, how the floods begin: far away, in a small stream, with a sound nobody hears yet. After that there is no turning them.

2. The boy of the cord

That night, after watching him go down the path, Amparo did not sleep.

It was not the anxious kind of sleeplessness, the heart-pounding kind. It was something else, more like a house where someone has left a door open: a draught moving where it shouldn't, a thin current running through every room and letting nothing settle. The question she had asked her son was walking about inside the house. And you. How will you get up, yourself? She had never asked it. In thirty-six years, never. And now that she had, the question would not be quiet, and it did what new questions do in old houses: it went along opening every door, one by one, back to the first.

The first door was a winter night, thirty-six years earlier, and Amparo knew it by heart.

Salvo was born facing death. There is no other way to say it, and in the family no way of saying it was ever found. He came into the world with the cord wound twice around his neck, purple as a plum, silent. The midwife, who was the oldest in the village

and had seen everything there was to see, gave him up for lost once, worked, gave him up for lost a second time, worked harder. Fortunato was in the kitchen heating water that nobody had asked for anymore, because men's hands at such times must be given something to do. And Amparo, drained, her head burning, did the only thing within her reach: she made a promise.

She promised no one in particular. She was not a woman of long prayers, and the prayers of Véspera, like everything in the village, were short and practical. She promised inward, through clenched teeth, the way true promises are made: if this boy lives, I will hold him. Whatever it costs, I will hold him always.

At the midwife's third attempt, the boy cried.

It was a small cry, a kitten's cry, and the whole house reorganised itself around it in that very instant, the way iron filings reorganise themselves around a magnet. The midwife said it was a miracle and went off with her payment and her glory. Fortunato wept in the yard, in secret, and came in with his face washed. And Amparo took the purple son who was breathing after all and gave him the name she had promised, so that he would

never forget, so that no one would ever forget, that this boy had come from the border and could, at any moment of carelessness, go back across it.

Salvo.

The village found it beautiful. The Keeper of the Register, who in those days was a young woman with broad hands, wrote the name in the book in her upright hand and said only, as she blotted the ink: a name like that is a load for a man to carry. Amparo did not understand, that day. She thought it was the envy of a woman without children. She carried the boy home wrapped in three blankets, in the coldest winter anyone remembered since the Great Winter, and began, without knowing it, to build the prison of her own hands.

The first year she slept with her hand on his chest. All of it.

That is not a figure of speech. She slept the entire year with her hand resting on her son's chest, counting his breaths, because her body had learned on the night of the birth that this breathing could stop, and what is learned once with that much fear is not easily unlearned. She woke ten times a night. Fortunato

would say, half asleep, leave the boy, woman, the boy is well. And she would leave him, for ten minutes. The hands went back on their own.

And the boy grew. He grew handsome, healthy, quick, with his father's easy laugh and her eyes. There was nothing wrong with him, and that was what nobody understood, not even Amparo herself: the boy was well, and she could not let go. Other children's fevers were fevers; his were warnings. Other children's falls were falls; his were near-disasters he escaped by a hair, and every hair's breadth added itself to the first one, the one of the cord, in a sum that only she kept running and that always came out the same: no risks can be taken.

Years later, the new doctor would ask her, in that way people from away have of asking things: what exactly are you afraid of? And Amparo would answer, without thinking: of arriving late. The doctor took it for an old woman's answer. It was not. It was the most exact truth of her life. Amparo had spent thirty-six years arriving on time, every day, at every hour, because once, on the first night of all, her son had nearly left in the space of a moment's carelessness that never even happened.

And there was Vera.

Vera was four when her brother was born, and the oldest memory she kept, she would say as a grown woman, laughing, not laughing, was of sitting at the opposite corner of the table watching her mother count breaths. No one sent her to that corner. Houses assign their places without words, and the house, that winter, needed a little girl who gave no trouble, and Vera, who was as quick as her mother, understood it in an instant and went and took the place. She learned to eat without spilling, to be ill without fever, to fall without crying. She learned, above all, the art that would accompany her all her life and that no teacher teaches: the art of needing little. If her mother was full, the girl made herself light. That was the arithmetic of love in that kitchen, and Vera was always good at sums.

Amparo saw. This is the part that is hard to say, and the book of a life must say it: Amparo saw. She saw her daughter making herself small in the corner and said inwardly, as soon as Salvo is better, as soon as this phase passes, I will make it up to her. The phases stitched themselves one to the next like days. The girl grew up impeccable, first in her class, gifted, never a worry. And once, Vera would have been about twelve, a neighbour said to Amparo in the square, with honest admiration: that eldest of yours hardly seems a child at all. Amparo said thank you and

carried the sentence crosswise in her chest for the rest of the day, without knowing why. Now she knew. It was not a compliment. It was the death certificate of a childhood, drawn up by a neighbour who did not know what she was writing.

But the destiny of a house is not made of fear alone. It is made of fear with help, and the help came from everywhere, mild, smiling, impossible to refuse. When Salvo broke the school window, it was his mother who went, and the teacher, who knew the story of the cord as the whole village did, said boys will be boys, it was nothing, and the bill for the glass never came. When Salvo, at fourteen, took the landlady's son's bicycle without asking and left it in the river, Fortunato wanted the boy to go and apologise and work off the repair. Amparo went first. She went first without telling anyone, smoothed the road, paid half, and by the time Salvo arrived, ears down, rehearsed by his father, there was no apology left to make: the landlady received him with cake. Fortunato never knew. Salvo never knew. And the boy learned, that day and on a thousand days like it, something nobody ever told him in words and that he came to know better than his times tables: between him and consequences there was always a body. He did not need to see it to count on it.

There were warnings. There were always warnings, she understood now, lying with her eyes open in the dark: life warns; what is missing is someone able to hear. The schoolteacher, in the early years, called her in one afternoon, closed the classroom door and laid Salvo's exercise books side by side: the homework in one handwriting, the classwork in another. You help him a great deal, the teacher said, without any malice. Amparo said yes, with pride, that she helped him every night. I don't doubt it, said the woman, and took a moment choosing her next words. The trouble is that I cannot teach the boy, because the boy never arrives here. Between him and the mistake there is always you, and the mistake is where I do my work. Amparo left the school offended, and the offence lasted her years. It was easier than the offence being right.

And there was Lurdes, later, Salvo's first serious sweetheart, a girl of few words who lasted three years and whom Amparo came to hold dear. When she left, she came to say goodbye to her, to the mother, which was strange in itself, and at the door, suitcase in hand, she said the sentence that Amparo filed away at the time in the drawer of injustices and that now, this night,

unfolded itself whole again: I loved him truly, dona Amparo. But at Salvo's side there is no chair for anyone else. The one there was, you are already sitting in it.

Leave the boy, woman, Fortunato used to say. You don't let him be.

He said it without anger, at the table, rolling his tobacco. He was a mild man, from the lower fields, who understood seeds and waiting times, and who looked at his son the way one looks at good land badly ploughed. Once, one single time in forty years of marriage, he raised his voice over this. Salvo was seventeen and had his first job, at Justo's warehouse: loading, unloading, stacking, fixed hours. He lasted seven weeks. He came late, drifted off, broke what should not be broken, and Justo, who had patience but also had a warehouse, dismissed him on a Friday with his wages exact and not one word more.

Salvo came home laughing, the story already made: the man had it in for him, that was no work for a young fellow, better things were waiting. Fortunato went quiet in that way which in mild men is a shout. And Amparo served the dinner, laughed at what was there to laugh at, and on Monday morning, telling no one, went to the warehouse.

She remembered everything. The smell of sawdust and rope, Justo wiping his hands on his apron before shaking hers, the way he heard her out, without interrupting, while she asked. She was not asking him to take the boy back; she asked only that he not speak ill of him in the village, that the boy was young, that he would straighten out, and, if another opening should come along later, that he remember the boy had a good core. And Justo looked at her with eyes she never forgot, eyes that did not judge, which was worse, and said the sentence on which, thirty-six years later, on a sleepless night, Amparo was still paying interest:

"Of the boy I'll speak no ill, senhora. The boy has good hands. Now you, if you'll allow me, ought to let him use his own."

Amparo thanked him, bought right there, out of shame, half a kilo of nails she had no need of, and went home by the upper path so as to speak to no one. That night Fortunato asked her where she had been in the morning, and she said at the shop. It was the first lie of the marriage. The nails sat for years in a tin in the pantry, beside the flour, and never nailed anything.

And it was curious, she thought now, in bed, eyes on the ceiling: the house had two tins, after all, side by side on the same shelf, and she had never seen them as the pair they were. The flour tin, with the money for his falls. And the tin of nails, with her shame. One kept what was given too much, the other what was kept too quiet, and both had been born of the same gesture: covering. Thirty years feeding the two tins, in secret, and the house above them, in everyone's sight, always so tidy, so upright, so praised. Houses always have one high shelf where the truth lives, and that is why the high shelf was invented: so the truth stays out of reach of the days.

The next door of memory Amparo opened in the small hours, lying with her eyes on the ceiling: and it was the usual door, the one that hurt always in the same place. Fortunato dying, six winters back, in the next room, slowly and with good manners, as he did everything in his life. In the last days he spoke little and only of essentials. He called Vera in and told her things Vera never repeated. And to her, to the wife of forty years of bed and table, he left a single request, said hand in hand, his eyes already half elsewhere:

"Don't stay fastened to the boy, Amparo. He will only be able to be a man when he has nowhere to fall."

She remembered everything of those last days, with the cruel sharpness last days leave behind. The room smelling of lavender, because Glória brought sprigs of it and did not know how to sit still. Custódia on guard at the door, regulating the visits like a keeper at a level crossing. Salvo, who came in and went out and could not stay, because the men of that family had never learned how to remain where it hurts, and his father, instead of pinning him to the chair, said go, go on, son, and followed him with his eyes to the door with a resigned love that Amparo only understood years later. And Vera, who stayed. Vera always stayed, in silence, in the corner of the room, doing the right things at the right times, and now and then her father would reach out his hand and she would hold it, and in that holding of hands there was an entire conversation that not even death interrupted, and Amparo, remembering it now, understood that she had always been jealous of it: of the rest those two found in each other, the two strong ones of the house, the two who gave no trouble, resting in one another by turns.

She promised. Of course she promised; one promises everything to those who are leaving. And she buried her husband, and kept her mourning, and before the mourning was a month old she had already paid, with nobody knowing, Salvo's first big debt in the big town, because a promise was one thing and her son was another, and between the two, her hands never had a moment's doubt.

Outside, the cocks were starting. Amparo got up without having slept, lit the fire, set the water to warm. The hands went ahead, as always, but she came behind watching them, and that was new. She watched them the way one watches a familiar road from a new window: the same road, another light. Thirty-six years of arriving on time. A promise made to a purple newborn, honoured to the day, with interest, through an entire life. And at the end of the account, on the other side of the table, a man of thirty-six who still did not know where the ground was, because no one had ever let him touch it.

The question of the night before came back with the morning light. And you. How will you get up, yourself?

And for the first time Amparo understood, with a shiver that was not the cold, that the question had not been only for her son.

3. The envelope

Spring came to Véspera the way it always came: first to the river, then to the fields, last of all to the people. Amparo was in the vegetable garden when Salvo's landlady found her, and she knew at once, from the way the woman came up the path, that she was not coming with good news. Bad news has a walk of its own. Anyone who has lived what Amparo had lived recognises it from far off, as dogs recognise thunder.

"Dona Amparo, I don't like speaking of these things."

It was true. The landlady was a dry, upright woman, a widow like herself, owner of two houses on the river street, and in twenty years she had never once come to that garden. She stood there with her hands crossed over her stomach, looking at the cabbages as if the cabbages were to blame, and Amparo set down the hoe and waited, because she already knew, deep down she had known since the start of the month, the way one knows things not yet known: by a silence in the place where a word should have been.

"The rent," the landlady said. "This month and the last. I waited, because I know how things are, but it's two months, dona Amparo. And I have my own accounts to keep."

The last month. Amparo heard the two words and did, inwardly, very fast, the sum she did not want to do. The last month she had put the envelope on the table, beside his plate. Counted, note by note. It covers the rent, this time. And Salvo had said I know, Mother, and had taken the envelope, and the envelope, it turned out, had never reached the river street.

"It will all be settled this week," said Amparo, in her usual voice, the smooth voice she kept for the village. "There was some confusion over payments at the building site. Contractors' business, you know how it is."

The landlady knew. Everyone always knew everything, in Véspera, and that was the rule of the game: to know everything and accept the version. The woman said her thank-yous, praised the cabbages for the sake of saying something, and went away down the path with her thunderstorm walk already lighter, because the thunderstorm had changed houses now: it had stayed in the garden, inside Amparo, darkening.

He didn't pay. The sentence walked round her head all morning while her hands did the garden by themselves. It was not the missing money. The money, God alone knew how, was always found. It was something else, something new and cold: for the first time in thirty-six years, Amparo had seen her help fail from the inside. She had always believed, without ever thinking it, that what she did held her son up. That every rent paid, every debt crossed out, every road smoothed was a stone in a wall, and that the wall, well or badly, was rising. That morning, among the cabbages, she saw the wall as it was. There was no wall. There was water. She had been dropping stones into water for thirty-six years, and the water closed over them, smooth, ready for the next stone.

At midday she did not eat. She sat at the kitchen table with a shop notebook she had bought once for garden notes, and a pencil, and did something she had never in her life done.

She did the accounts.

Not the month's accounts. All of them. She began with what she remembered from far back, not the warehouse, that one had not cost money, it had cost something else, and moved up through the years: the motorbike he bought and wrecked, the tools

bought twice because the first set stayed behind at a job he left in anger, the partnership with the cousin that lasted one summer, the rents, the rents, the rents, the big debt in the big town paid in secret in the month of Fortunato's mourning, the shop credit crossed out at every month's beginning for twenty years. She wrote slowly, in the large hand of a woman who learned her letters as an adult, and she was not writing out of grievance. She was writing in order to see. There are things that only exist once they are written, and Amparo's life, in what touched her son, had never been written: it was lived day to day, in small secrets, in flour tins, in envelopes, and each expense, seen alone, was reasonable, was love, was what any mother would do. They had to be set in a column for the size of the thing to show.

Some lines took longer than others, because they came with the story attached. The motorbike, for instance. Salvo was twenty-two when he bought it, second-hand, against everyone's advice, with money that was half his and half an advance from his mother which remained, like every advance in that house, an account kept in cloud: visible, never touched. The motorbike lasted a year and a half. It died one night on a harmless bend, nobody hurt, mercifully, and what was left of it sold for nothing. Amparo wrote the number down and sat looking at it: she re-

membered that that winter she had not had her coat relined, and the coat needed relining. Nobody knew. That was the method of the flour tin: what went out for him was deducted from her, in silence, in linings postponed, in teeth that waited, in spectacles that went on serving. Her son's column had a mirror written in no ledger anywhere: the column of her own goings-without. She wrote that one too, from memory, alongside, shorter only because memory hurts less on the inward side.

And the partnership with the cousin. That line cost her in another way, because it had been the time she believed most. A whole summer of plans at the table, Salvo and the cousin from the big town, a tool resale business, papers and everything, and she listening from the kitchen and letting herself be carried, because a mother's hope has no judgement and wants none. She came in with the starting money; she called it a loan; she always knew she was misnaming it. The partnership came apart in September, like the swallows, and the cousin and Salvo were on bad terms for a year, and the money was never spoken of again: in the family, Amparo had long since discovered, debts were not forgiven, they were dissolved, since forgiving still obliges you to say the thing's name, and dissolving does not.

By mid-afternoon the notebook had four written pages and Amparo was certain of two things. The first: that between rents, debts and patchings, she had given her son, over a lifetime, more than she had given herself since she was widowed. The second, worse: that she could not remember one single one of those times when the money had changed anything. It solved the month. It never solved anything.

She closed the notebook and put it away in the pantry, on the high shelf, beside the flour tin. She noticed the tin of nails, further back, with thirty years of dust. She did not touch it.

Salvo appeared two days later, at the end of the afternoon, and he came in light, almost cheerful, and Amparo understood, the moment he entered, that he did not know she knew. She served him the coffee her hands had already made, sat down opposite, and instead of asking about the rent, asked about the site, the workmates, the weather. She had decided to wait. She wanted to see whether he would say it. She wanted to give him the open door, the chance to be the one to say Mother, something happened, and for half an hour her son talked about everything in

the world except that, with the easy laugh, with the funny stories, and the door stood open the whole time, and he walked past it every time without so much as a glance.

It was she who opened her mouth in the end, and she hated herself a little for it.

"Your landlady was here."

Salvo's laugh did what she knew so well: it did not go out, it changed function. It went from laugh to shield.

"Ah. Right. I was going to tell you about that, Mother." And then came the story, and the story, as always, was good, was human, stood on its own feet. Adelino, his workmate from the site, was about to be put out on the street with his wife and children, three months of rent behind, the man desperate, crying beside him on the scaffolding, a grown man, Mother, crying. And he had had the envelope money right there, that day, in his pocket. "And I thought: my landlady will wait, she knows me. Adelino couldn't wait. You'd have done the same, Mother. You made me this way."

You made me this way.

Amparo sat a moment without words, and the moment was not anger. It was mirror. She looked at her son and saw, with a clarity that hurt, what he had done: he had given money that was not his to catch another man's fall, and he had done it without a second thought, heart ahead of the sums, and the part about the sums, the part about knowing where his own rent would come from, that part had stayed, as always, for the body that came behind. For her. Her son had learned the whole gesture from her. He had only never learned the cost, because the cost had never once been his.

"You did right by Adelino," she said slowly. "And wrong by your word. Both things, Salvo. They don't cancel each other out."

"I'll pay, Mother. As soon as I'm paid, I'll set everything straight."

"I know you will." And she knew more: she knew it was she who would set it straight, because two months of rent do not come out of a site worker's wages, and an eviction does not wait on good intentions. Her hands, under the table, had already begun doing the sums of the tin. This time she caught them halfway and stopped them, and the effort of stopping them was so great that it came out of her in words, the words she had sworn not to say yet: "I'll deal with your landlady this week."

"Mother, there's no need, I..."

"There is need, Salvo." And she looked him in the eye. "But know this: it is the last rent I pay without your knowledge. From now on, whatever I pay is counted out in front of you and written in a notebook. Does Adelino know how much he owes you?"

Salvo blinked, caught.

"Of course he does."

"Then you are going to know how much you owe me. It isn't for the collecting." She felt for the words, which were new to her. "It's because a thing that isn't written down doesn't weigh. And you need to feel the weight, son. Without weight, nobody learns to carry."

It was the longest speech she had made him in years, and Salvo heard it out with the air of a man listening to rain: patient, waiting for the sun, certain it would pass. He kissed her, promised the usual, took half of yesterday's cake with him and went off down the path whistling. Amparo stayed at the window, as always. She noticed he had Fortunato's walk and the feet of a man in no hurry at all.

She went to pay the landlady on Friday morning, early, at her own hour, the hour when the village is not yet at its windows. The woman's house was on the river street, three doors down from Salvo's, and Amparo noticed, passing, that her son's shutters were still down, and did not let the noticing leave a mark: it was Friday, the site was stopped, a man may sleep. The landlady received her in the kitchen, the oilcloth table already laid with two cups, because she knew she was coming, naturally, in Véspera it was always known, and this was a ceremony with rules both women knew: the coffee that is accepted, the small talk of weather that is made, and only then the money, counted out on the oilcloth, slowly, without indecent haste.

"Two months, and this one to the day," said Amparo, smoothing the notes. "And my apologies for the delay, which is not our habit."

"It is not, no," said the landlady, putting the money away in her own tin, for every house had its own. And then, at the door, with Amparo already leaving, she could not resist, because nobody resists every time, and she said it without malice, which was worse: "Don't take it amiss. I knew your mother, when you were

still in arms. Just now, watching you count the money on my table, it was her over again. You are your mother to the life, dona Amparo."

Amparo thanked her, because it was a compliment, because from that woman's mouth it could only be a compliment. And she walked the whole of the river street, and the climb to the square, and the road home, with the compliment lodged where small fishbones lodge, and halfway up the climb she found herself answering it in her head, answering the landlady, the village, the morning: so I am. And that is exactly what I no longer want to be.

The telephone rang at night. It was Vera, and Vera, married in the big town but with ears in Véspera, came straight to it as she always did:

"Mother, is it true Salvo's landlady came to the garden?"

And here happened the thing Amparo would remember most when, months later, she thought back on this month: she heard her own voice answering, smooth, without a flicker.

"She did, she did. It was about some mix-up with receipts, it's all sorted now. Her business."

Lying to her daughter was nothing new. She had been lying for thirty years, in small doses, with good intent: so as not to set Vera against her brother, not to hand Vera's hardness its proofs, to keep the family whole around one table. The novelty was something else: she heard herself. She stood outside it, as she had in the kitchen with the envelope, and watched the lie leave her mouth, round, practised, and recognised its pitch. It was her mother's voice. It was the exact voice of her mother at the wall telephone of the house of the Olive Press, forty years ago, telling a neighbour that Amadeu was away working, that all was well, that people with nothing better to do would talk.

On the other end, Vera made a pause that lasted too long.

"All right, Mother," she said at last, and in her voice went the weariness of someone setting down, yet again, a thing that is heavy. "All sorted, then."

They hung up. Amparo stood with the telephone in her hand, in the dark hallway, a long time. Then she went to the pantry, took the notebook from the high shelf and, on the fifth page, beneath

all the sums, wrote in her large hand a line that was not a number.

Today I lied to Vera on his account. The way my mother lied on Amadeu's.

She looked at the sentence. It was the truest thing she had written in her life. And with the sentence written there came to her a new and strange urge, almost a dizziness: to pick up the telephone, ring her daughter back, and tell her everything. I lied to you just now. The rent isn't paid, your brother gave the money to a workmate, I am going to pay it on Friday in secret the way I have paid everything for thirty years, and I am tired, Vera, I am so tired of this that I don't even know where my tiredness begins. She got as far as the hallway. She got as far as putting her hand on the telephone, and the telephone was the same wall telephone from the house of the Olive Press, moved house with her, and perhaps it was that, her hand resting on the instrument where her own mother had rested the same lie so many times, that stopped her. She did not ring. She was not ready, and there are things that cannot be forced, in others or in ourselves. But she stood there a moment, in the dark hallway, hand on the telephone, doing something she had never done: measuring the

exact distance between what she was and what she wanted to be. The distance was one telephone number. She would dial it one day. It was agreed with herself, there, undated, the way right things are agreed.

She closed the notebook, put it away, turned off the pantry light. And passing through the dark kitchen, without needing to see, she knew exactly where the flour tin stood, how much was in it, and how many days were left until the beginning of the month.

4. The saint

The spring feast had been held in Véspera since before anyone's memory, and it was always held the same way: the long table was set up in the square, along the old churchyard terrace, every house brought what it had and what it could, and for an afternoon and an evening the whole village ate of the same bread, as if the year's quarrels could fit under the tablecloth. It was in honour of no saint, no harvest, no date. It was in honour of the winter being over. In Véspera one did not celebrate what one had: one celebrated what one had withstood.

Amparo woke that day at five, as she had woken on every feast day of her life, because the village feasts rested on half a dozen pairs of hands and hers were two of them. She made the house's cakes, the usual ones, the ones people asked for by name. She killed and dressed two chickens. She carried down to the square, in three trips, the trays, the big cloths and the largest pot, and by ten in the morning she was standing, kerchief on her head, among the other women, setting up the street kitchen, at the post she had held for forty years without anyone ever having given it to her: the post of the one who can be counted on.

She liked it, and it matters to say it plainly, without shame: she liked it. She liked the noise of the women, the crossed orders, the smell of wood smoke and bay leaf, the children underfoot, old Justo sitting in the corner sharpening everyone's knives in exchange for a glass and some talk, for his back was no longer good for loads but his hand for an edge was still the best in the village. She liked being needed. When a young neighbour asked her where the platters went, and another shouted ask Amparo, Amparo's the one who knows, she felt in her chest the old warmth, the one pride she allowed herself. Amparo's the one who knows. Amparo arrives on time. Amparo holds.

It was around midday that the word appeared.

It came in the mouth of the contractor's wife, a well-turned-out lady who came to the feasts with small pots and large opinions, and it came wrapped in praise, as it always came:

"Dona Amparo is a saint. What this woman does for her family, and still has hands left over for the whole village. A saint, I tell you."

There was a murmur of agreement around the pot, one of those murmurs which in Véspera have the force of a notarised deed. Amparo smiled the usual smile and stirred the rice. And it was then, wooden spoon in hand and steam on her face, that the thing happened: the word, for the first time in her life, sat wrong. She felt it go down and lodge crosswise, like a small fish-bone. Saint. She had heard that word a thousand times and a thousand times stored it away as one stores an honour. Now she heard it and saw something else: she saw the square, this same square, forty years earlier, and the women of that time, around another pot, saying it of her mother.

Amparo's mother is a saint. What that woman does for her son.

And she saw, as if it were today, what the word covered.

The whole village knew about Amadeu. It was known without being said, the way things were known in Véspera: the eldest of the house of the Olive Press, the handsomest boy of his generation, the one who could play anything with strings by ear, the one whom at twenty everyone swore would become somebody, and who kept staying. He stayed on at the café, stayed on in the partnerships that came apart, stayed on in the small debts his mother went along paying, stayed on at the corner of the table,

with the glass, with the guitar further and further out of tune, with the stories of what he was going to do next year. And as Amadeu stayed, the village went changing its word. First he was a boy lucky to have such a mother. Then he was a boy without luck. At last, and it lasted years, he was only poor soul, said low, with a shake of the head: poor soul, Amadeu, and right after it, always, in the same breath, saintly woman, the mother.

Nobody, in forty years, put the two sentences together. Nobody said: and what if the one made the other? The village had no malice. It had eyes, but words serve to cover as much as to say, and that pair of words, poor soul and saint, was the roof under which the house of the Olive Press could go quietly rotting with everyone watching and no one looking.

"Dona Amparo, the rice!"

The rice had caught on the bottom. Amparo saved it with the practice of sixty years of rice, laughed with the others at the scare, and carried the fishbone crosswise in her for the rest of the afternoon, serving, smiling, arriving on time for everything, exactly like a saint.

At the long table, late in the afternoon, there came the moment that always came, and which Amparo had never known whether the village noticed: someone brought out a guitar. There was always one, at the feasts, and there was always the instant when the boy who carried it tuned it, head bowed, and in that instant, every year, the women over sixty went quiet for a moment, eyes in the air, and none of them said why, and all of them knew: it was Amadeu. The whole village kept his sound stored inside the sound of every guitar being tuned, and that, Amparo understood this year, was her brother's true grave: not the plot in the cemetery, but that half minute of the old women's silence, every year, at the same hour, which nobody arranged and nobody missed.

And she saw too, this year, for the first time, a thing that must always have been in plain sight and which she had never once noticed: the Keeper of the Register, seated at the foot of the long table, in the last place on the terrace side, eating slowly, alone and without any loneliness, watching the whole feast the way one reads. Nobody sat beside her and nobody failed to greet her. The places at Véspera's table had their laws, and the law of that place was old: to the one who writes the village down, the village gives distance and bread. When the two women's eyes met

over the platters, the Keeper gave her a small nod, and Amparo returned it, and thought no more of it. Only months later, in the room of the great books, would she remember that nod and wonder, without an answer, what the woman had already read in her that afternoon.

Salvo arrived at the feast when the afternoon was on its downward slope, fresh, good-humoured, in a clean shirt, and the feast, as always, opened to receive him. It was impossible not to like him, and the village liked him, in the easy way one likes a man who makes us laugh and owes us nothing directly. He helped hang the lights, played with the children, had a word by name for every old woman. Amparo watched him move through the crowd and saw two things at once, as she saw everything now, with the new window: she saw the charming son who filled the square, and she saw Amadeu, forty years ago, in this same square, doing exactly this, with this same talent, living on the interest of a future that never arrived.

And then she saw, across the long table, a small thing that tightened her stomach. Salvo in conversation with cousin Henrique, Glória's son, come from the big town for the feast. Laughter, hand on shoulder, that dance she knew by heart. And at a cer-

tain point, in one quick and perfectly natural gesture, Henrique taking out his wallet and passing him something, and Salvo pocketing it with a handshake and one more joke, all of it in three seconds, all of it in everyone's sight and invisible to everyone.

To everyone but two. Because when Amparo looked away, she met Custódia's eyes, which from the other end of the table had seen the same scene. The two sisters looked at each other over the whole feast, and nothing needed saying. Custódia was seventy-one and watching was her trade. She was the family's sentinel, the one who rang to know the weather where you were, the one who kept all the dates, the one who never, under any circumstances, was caught off guard. She gave Amparo a small sign with her head, towards the end of the square, and Amparo understood: later, when this is over.

The feast ended as it always ended, children asleep on shoulders and the men stacking tables with more noise than method. At midnight, in the half-stripped square, the usual women stayed to wash the bulk of the crockery at the spout of the old washing tank, because the spring water was for the serra to give, and Véspera washed its feast dishes where it had always washed

them. It fell out, as it had fallen out since they were girls, that the three sisters ended up together at the end: Custódia washing, Glória drying, Amparo stacking. Birth order, Glória would say, laughing, commands even the dishes.

It was Custódia who began, without a sideways glance, scrubbing a platter that was already clean:

"How much did Henrique lend him?"

"I don't know," said Amparo. "I didn't want to know."

"I know," said Glória, and the two of them looked at her. Glória shrugged, cloth in hand. "Henrique told me in the car. It's nothing much, it's till the end of the month. The boy's in a tight spot with the site stopped, poor soul."

Poor soul. The word fell into the tank water and Amparo felt it sink slowly, with forty years of weight. She looked at Glória, at her middle sister, good as bread, incapable of thinking ill of anyone living, and understood that she was looking at one of the mechanism's hands. Glória excused. She had always excused everyone; it was her nature and her sweetness, and every excuse was a drop of oil in the gearing that kept the wheel turning

smooth: Salvo asked, Henrique gave, Glória excused, Amparo paid, the village said poor soul and saint, and the wheel went round once more without so much as a creak.

"It was like this with Amadeu," said Amparo.

She said it low, to the water, but in the silence of the square the sentence stood enormous. Glória stopped her cloth. Custódia did not stop her hands, and it was that which told Amparo that her elder sister had been waiting for this for a long time.

"Amadeu was different," said Glória, too quickly. "Amadeu was ill."

"Ill with what, Glória?" Custódia's voice came calm and cutting, as it always came when she decided not to pretend. "Go on. Ill with what, at twenty, when Mother paid his first? And at thirty, when she paid his hundredth? The illness came at the end, that it did. At the beginning there was no illness at all. At the beginning there was a boy with talent and a mother who would not let the world land on him. The illness was what grew in between."

"She did everything out of love."

"She did," said Custódia. "And I never said otherwise." She set down the platter at last and looked at her sisters, first at Glória, then at Amparo, and on this one she lingered. "Now you'll both answer me one thing, because I wash dishes but I don't wash memories. Who caught Amadeu every time he fell?"

"Mother did," said Glória.

"And who caught Amadeu the last time, when Mother was no longer here to catch him?"

Silence. The spout running. Amparo felt the night's cold come in through her back, because she knew the answer, and the answer was no one. Their mother died in a borrowed bed, rested as a worker at shift's end, with Amadeu still there, at the corner of the table of the house of the Olive Press. And Amadeu, without the body that had always stood between him and the ground, lasted three years. It was not from one day to the next; it was fall by fall, each one deeper, the way a man falls who learned to fall for sixty years being caught: without hands. When he went, the village said poor soul one last time and came whole to the funeral, and there were those who said, on the way out, that at least his mother was no longer here to see it. As if that were the story's mercy, and not its sentence.

"I watched you both today," Custódia went on, lower now. "I watched the whole feast call you a saint, Amparo. And I watched your face." She reached out her wet hand and touched her sister's arm, a rare thing in her. "Mother heard that word her whole life and died without ever hearing its underside. You are still in time to hear it. That's all I'm saying."

Glória was pressing the cloth to her chest, distressed, tears standing in her eyes, because Glória cried easily and loved her sisters and wanted, as she had always wanted, for nobody to say anything more and everyone to go home on good terms.

"You're speaking of Mother as if she did harm," she said, voice trembling. "She gave her life for him."

"She did," said Amparo.

And she heard herself ask, aloud, in the empty square, hands in the cold water, the question that had spent a lifetime locked inside the house of the Olive Press, in the pantry of every conversation, behind all the tins:

"And what if that was the harm, Glória? Giving her life for him. Maybe it was his own life he needed, not hers." She turned to Custódia, and her voice came out younger than she was, or much older: "You who saw it all from the beginning. Do you think Mother helped him, or do you think Mother finished him?"

Custódia did not answer.

She stayed silent a long time, the sentinel, hands still in the water, and what she did was what the women of the house of the Olive Press did instead of answering: she looked. She looked at Amparo's hands, at length, in no hurry at all to look away, until Amparo caught herself following her eyes and looking too, and there the two sisters stood, at one in the morning, in the square of Véspera, looking at a pair of hands red with cold water as one looks at the only answer there was.

It was Glória who broke the moment, because that was her office in the sisterhood, to smooth, and thank goodness someone had it:

"This water's turned to ice. We'll talk tomorrow, tomorrow's another day."

They put away the rest in silence. And at the parting, trays already on hips, Glória, who could not bear to leave with the thing badly stitched, tried her patch once more: now, now, don't be angry at Mother, Mother did everything for the best. And Custódia, already walking away towards her own street, answered without stopping and without raising her voice, and the answer stayed echoing in the empty square long after she had vanished round the corner: nobody's angry at Mother, Glória. Mother did everything for the best. Faustino went for the best, Amadeu went for the best, there's a whole plot of this village's people buried in the shade of for the best. All I say is enough of best done that way. Good night, girls.

They parted with the usual kisses, each to her own house by her own road, three old women across the square with empty trays. Amparo climbed hers slowly. At her door, before going in, she did a thing she had not done since girlhood: she turned to look back, at the village in the dark, at all the roofs under the enormous sky, and sought out, among them, the roof of the house of the Olive Press, where Perpétua slept now, the cousin who had stayed to hold everything. And she said, voiceless, to the night, to her mother, to the fishbone that had been crosswise in her since midday:

"I don't judge you. But I'm not following you any further."

Then she went in, and shut the door, and the latch made a small, final click in the night, like Benvinda's pencil striking a line through the ledger.

Next morning the square dawned washed and empty, as it always dawned after the feasts, with the marks of the tables in the packed earth and half a dozen glasses forgotten on windowsills, and the village woke late and at peace, not knowing something in it had shifted during the night, by the washing tank, between three sisters and a question. Véspera's changes were like that, Amparo had spent her life learning without knowing she learned: they never came on the announced days, the great dates, the events. They came during the clearing-up, among the dishes, at the ends of feasts, on the quiet, like water along the irrigation channels: you open it a hand's width of path with the hoe and it seems not to go, and it doesn't go, and suddenly it is there, it has run the whole channel, and the earth at the bottom, which was pale, has turned dark, and nobody ever saw it dry again.

5. The body

The summer came early that year and settled in with every intention of staying. The river Fundo shrank back to its August bed, the serra took on that colour of well-baked bread, and Véspera entered its old hot-weather timetable: rise at dawn, stop in the middle of the day, live again towards evening. Amparo had always liked the summer for the same reason she liked the feasts: it gave more to do.

It was on a watering morning that her body spoke to her for the first time.

She was bent over the channel, straightening the water with the hoe, when the world turned half over. It was not pain. It was as if someone, for a joke, had moved the ground somewhere else: the garden tilted all together to the left, the cabbages went up, the sky came down, and Amparo found herself sitting on the wet earth with no idea how she had got there, the hoe still in her hand and her heart beating in her ears like a cracked bell.

She sat there a minute. Two. The world came back to its place, ashamed of itself. A midge sang at her ear. And Amparo then did what she had always done with everything that happened to her, to her: she filed the matter away. She got up carefully, finished the watering more slowly, and at home made a tea from the yard herb, the house's universal remedy, which served for the stomach, for the nerves and for the things one does not speak of. She told no one. Who would make the lunch?

The second time was a week later, in the kitchen, without warning. She was reaching for the high shelf of the pantry, the usual one, and her left hand simply did not go. She ordered it, and the hand did not go. It stopped halfway, trembling a small tremble like an animal in the cold, and the big preserve jar, already in her right, slipped and undid itself on the floor in glass, tomato and silence. Amparo looked at the disaster a long time. Not because of the jar. Because of the hand. Her hands had never, in sixty-three years, refused an order. They were the oldest and most faithful part of what she was. To see them fail was like hearing the house creak in a place where it had never creaked: it may be nothing. But whoever knows the house does not sleep the same.

She picked up the glass, washed the floor, and by the time she wrung the cloth the left hand was obeying again, as if nothing had happened. She told no one. But in Véspera, telling and being known were different things, and two days later Custódia knocked at her door with no pretext at all, which in Custódia was the gravest pretext of all.

"You sat down in the garden last Thursday," said the elder sister, taking off her kerchief, still in the hallway. "At nine-something in the morning. In the middle of the channel."

"Who told you?"

"Véspera." Custódia sat down in the kitchen in her usual place. "And last week you broke a big jar, which your neighbour heard, and that afternoon you didn't hang out washing, and you have hung out washing every afternoon of your life. Shall I go on, or shall we save time?"

The sentinel kept a file on the entire family, and Amparo had always thought it a quirk, sometimes a cross. In that kitchen, that morning, she understood for the first time that it was also a form of love, the only one Custódia had managed to make out of the fear she inherited: their mother had lost a small son to a few

minutes' distraction, and Custódia had decided, from the height of her seven years of age, that on her watch no one would ever be lost again. Each had built her own prison out of the same fright. Amparo had made hands of it. Custódia had made eyes.

"You're going to the doctor," said Custódia. "The new one's here, at the post, Tuesdays and Fridays. The whole village has been already."

"There's nothing wrong with me. It was the heat."

"Of course. And the hand? Was the hand the heat too?"

Amparo opened her mouth to ask how she knew about the hand, and closed it. There was no point. Véspera.

The tests were done in the big town, and the trip to the tests lodged itself in both sisters' memories the way unplanned things do. Custódia insisted on going with her, naturally, for the sentinel delegated no watches, and the two of them caught the seven o'clock coach together, as they had not done since they were girls. And there happened to them what happens to old sisters when you sit them side by side for an hour with their hands empty: they fell to remembering. The olive press in

October, the smell of it, the purple legs. Their mother singing badly, for their mother sang badly like nobody else, and sang always. The day little Glória fell asleep inside the laundry basket and the whole house went shouting for her along the river. They laughed quietly, the two old women in the front seat, the bag of test papers on a lap, and Custódia, near the big town already, said without looking at her, in the tone of one remarking on the landscape: you were the one who laughed loudest, of the three of us. I remember it. I don't know what year it was you went quiet. And Amparo did not answer, and spent the rest of the road trying to remember the year, and could not, and that was an answer.

The new doctor was new in every sense: new to the village, new in age, new in her ways. She came from the big town twice a week, saw patients at the post that had been the old telephone exchange, the examination couch against the wall where the holes from Cordélia's switchboard could still be seen, and she treated the old people of Véspera with a mixture of respect and stubbornness that the village was still deciding whether it liked. Amparo went on the Friday, under orders from her sister, in her big-town clothes, prepared to be done with it in ten minutes.

It took an hour.

The doctor measured, listened, pressed, asked. Had her follow a finger with her eyes, squeeze her hands with all her strength, first the right, then the left. She lingered over the left. She ordered tests in the big town, wrote on a slip in a hand worse than any old man's, and then, when Amparo was already reaching for her bag, did the thing the village had not yet quite forgiven her: she put down her pen, leaned back in her chair and asked a question that was not an old-time doctor's question.

"How much do you sleep?"

"What's needed."

"How many hours?"

"Look, child, I sleep the hours life leaves me." And as the doctor waited, neither laughing nor giving up, Amparo shrugged: "Five. Four. Depends what sums there are to do in my head."

The doctor wrote. She asked about food, and Amparo answered with the meals she made for others. She asked about rest, and Amparo answered with the garden, which was her rest. She asked how long it had been since she had spent a day, one

whole day, doing nothing for anyone, and Amparo sat looking at her, genuinely searching, the way one turns out a deep drawer, and the longer she searched the more the question laughed at her, and at last she answered with the truth, which was that she did not know. There was no memory of it. Perhaps before she married. Perhaps never.

"Your blood pressure is high," said the doctor. "The dizziness and the hand may be that, and most likely are. We'll see the tests. But I'll tell you what I think, and you'll forgive me for being direct, I haven't yet learned to say things the way they're said here." She leaned forward. "Your body is on strike, dona Amparo. It isn't ill: it has had enough. Those are different things and they are treated in different ways. Medicine for blood pressure I can write you in a minute. Now tell me this, because this is what interests me: who is it, exactly, that you take care of?"

"My life," said Amparo, dry.

"And you. Who takes care of you?"

Amparo laughed. It came out on its own, a short, true laugh, because the question was so absurd it did not even offend: it was like asking the hoe who digs for it. The doctor did not laugh. She

sat looking at her with a sad patience, the patience of someone who had asked that question in that room of two dozen women of Véspera and heard that same laugh from every one, and the laugh, Amparo understood suddenly, with a chill, was the answer. The doctor waited for her patient to finish laughing at the question and then said, quietly, no drama in it, folding the test slip:

"You know, the village has been teaching me. I've understood by now that nobody here falls ill of illness. Here people fall of load. And then they call it age."

The tests came back a fortnight later and brought no disaster: the pressure, the sugars a touch high, things to be governed with a small pill and less salt. The doctor read her all the numbers, prescribed what there was to prescribe, and at the end, closing the folder, prescribed one thing more, without paper: you will give me one day a week without serving anyone. One. Choose the day. It is not rest, it is training, like training an arm after the plaster comes off: your muscle for staying still has wasted away entirely, and that is recovered slowly, like everything.

Amparo tried it the following Wednesday, and the book must tell the experiment, because she herself told it to Benvinda afterwards, crying with laughter. She decided to do nothing from lunch onward. She sat at the window with her hands in her lap at two in the afternoon. At ten past two she got up to dust a piece of furniture that was clean. She sat down again. At twenty past two she remembered that the neighbour below had a sick daughter and got up to take her a bowl of broth, and halfway across the yard she stopped, bowl in hand, catching what her legs had done on their own. She went back inside. The broth went at five, for sick is sick. Between two and five she got up from the chair, she told her friend, fourteen times, and on seven of them she could not even say what for. The muscle for staying still, the doctor had said. Wasted was generous: Amparo hunted for it all afternoon and could not find so much as the place where it should have been.

He came that Friday. And here the book must tell exactly what happened, because it was a small thing and one of the largest.

Salvo arrived in good form, talkative, hungry. Amparo had her head full of the doctor's words, her left arm still holding the memory of the tremble, and her body, all of it, for the first time

in her life, asking her for a chair. And for an hour, without noticing, without deciding anything, she did everything as she had always done: she heated, she served, she got up, sat down again, got up again to fetch the bread, got up a third time because he liked the other preserve, the one on the high shelf, the left hand's shelf. Only when he had gone, kissed and provisioned, and she was alone with the dishes, did she see herself: she saw the whole hour from outside, as she knew how to see now, and she counted. She had risen from the table eleven times. Her son, none. At none of the eleven had he said sit still, Mother, I'll go. But the fault, and this was the newest thing of all, the fault no longer seemed to her only his: eleven times are eleven invitations, and the one who had laid the table that way, a whole life long, was she.

That night, in bed, her hands would not close.

It was not the pantry tremble. It was something else: pure tiredness, deep, from inside the bones. Amparo lying on her back, her two hands open on the bedspread, sending them the simple order to close, and the hands obeying slowly, with effort, halfway, like doors in a house gone out of true. She lay like that a long time, in the dark, listening to the river far off, feeling her

own heart, and she waited for the fear of death, because she supposed that was what came next, that was what came to people her age on such nights.

While she waited, she took, for distraction, the inventory of the dark room, which was a map she knew by heart: her mother's maiden chest of drawers, inherited as the eldest of the living; the portrait of Fortunato on their wedding day, serious as he only ever was on that day and on the day of his funeral; the wardrobe with the winter clothes on the left and the summer on the right, changed over twice a year for forty years; and on the wall, the only thing hung there, the small frame with the dried flower Vera had brought her from school at eight years old and which had survived everything, removals, cleanings, decades, without anyone ever saying why. Everything in that room was from before or belonged to others. She searched, in the dark, for one single thing that was hers, chosen by her, for her, after she was grown, and the search was still going when the fear arrived and interrupted it.

The fear came. But it was not of death.

The thought formed by itself, sharp as the doctor's voice, and it was this, and she hated it the instant she saw it: if I go, who catches him?

Not: what will become of me. Not: I am afraid of leaving. Not even: who will look after Vera, the house, the garden. The first thought of her body before its own weakness was her son falling in a world without a net, and Amparo understood, lying there, with a terrible clearness, the full size of the prison. Not even the fear of death was her own. Even that the hands had taken from her: the right to fear for herself.

She turned on the light. She sat up in bed. And she said aloud, to the empty room, to the portrait of Fortunato on the chest of drawers, the strangest and most her own words she had said in years:

"I fall too."

The portrait did not answer, but it seemed to her, and she would have sworn to it, that the man from the lower fields smiled one millimetre more. Amparo put out the light, lay down on her side, and slept seven hours straight for the first time in woman's memory, hands open and resting in front of her chest, the way

very small children sleep, who hold nothing up yet and let nothing fall, because the world is still carried for them by someone else.

6. The papers

Vera came on a Sunday, without her husband and without her boy, which was in itself an announcement. When Vera wanted to be with her mother, she brought the family; when she wanted to talk to her mother, she came alone. She arrived with cake from the big-town bakery, kissed her, praised the garden, and over lunch talked about everything that did not matter, methodically, like someone clearing ground. Vera made conversations the way she made everything: in order.

Over coffee, she opened her bag and laid a blue plastic folder on the table.

"Mother, I've been thinking. After the scare in the garden, and what the doctor said..."

"The doctor said nothing. The pressure's right again."

"...and what the doctor said," Vera went on, without stopping, which was her way of disagreeing, "there are things we'd do well to get in order. Calmly. It's not for any reason, it's so that it's in order."

Inside the blue folder was Amparo's life in paper form: the house, the garden plot, her share of the house of the Olive Press, the certificates that needed requesting, the powers of attorney it would be wise to make. Vera had it all set down on one sheet, in numbered points, in that exact hand of hers. And at the bottom of the sheet, after all the points, came the two sentences that were the real reason for the Sunday, and Vera read them out as she had read the rest, without a change of tone, but unable to look at her mother:

"And I'd like you to think about coming to stay with us for a while. A month, two. The house has room, the back bedroom is quiet, you'd rest." She turned the page, as if the next page protected her. "And Joaquim says he can find Salvo work at the firm. Down south, at the depot. It's far, yes. But it's steady work, with a contract, and he'd be out of here. Sometimes, Mother, people only manage to change when they change ground."

A long silence settled on the kitchen. Outside, the hens. Amparo stirred the coffee that was already stirred and felt, before any thought, her body's answer: a tightening in the chest, a deep no, animal, prior to all reason. And right behind it, rising from the same deep place, the sentence. The sentence of always, the one

she had never spoken aloud to anyone, the one that had been the prop of her life for thirty-six years and which now, after the feast, after the washing tank, after the doctor, she could for the first time watch from outside even as she felt it from inside:

If I let go, he falls.

She did not say it. She said other things, the customary ones: that a house is not left just like that, that the garden in summer doesn't wait, that she would think about it. Vera heard out all the evasions with her eyes down on her sheet of points and, when her mother finished, nodded slowly, closed the folder, and said only, in a thread of voice that was not anger, it was worse, it was surrender:

"You won't let go of this even dead. I know. I just had to try."

And she changed the subject with the same order with which she had arrived at it, and the rest of the afternoon was mild. But at the parting, the car door already open, Vera stopped, keys in hand, and said one thing more, half turned away, in the lowest voice of the day: you think I come here to deal with papers. I know how it looks. I deal with papers when I'm afraid, Mother, it's my way, it always was: I put my fear into numbered points so

it will fit inside me. She got into the car, shut the door, lowered the window, and said, before pulling away: that thing in the garden frightened me, Mother. That was all the numbered points were trying to say.

And she drove off down the road. Amparo stood at the gate watching the car to the bend, the blue folder in her arms, an ache in a place no tests would ever show: her daughter had just shown her, for the first time in forty years, the underside of all that order, and the underside was a frightened little girl, and the frightened little girl had driven away again with no one having taken her up in their arms.

It was on account of the blue folder that, the following Wednesday, Amparo climbed the three worn steps of the House of Records.

It was a small, deep building, between the square and the churchyard terrace, smelling of old paper and wax, and it was there that the village had kept, from the beginning, its official memory: the books of births, of marriages and of deaths, the deeds, the plans, the wills of those who had made them. The Keeper attended at a desk of dark wood, no computer in sight, though it was said there was one in the back. Nobody knew for

certain how long that woman had been there. She was the age each person remembered her being, and the village had given up doing the sums.

The village had a relation with that house that it had with no other. One did not go there gladly, and nobody quite knew why, because the house did no one any harm: it kept. Perhaps that was it. In *Véspera* everyone lived by telling their own version, and the House of Records was the one place in the village where versions did not enter: in there, each person's life was reduced to what had actually happened, in half a dozen lines, without excuses and without trimmings, and there was something in that bareness that made people put off the visit for years on end. It was said the Keeper knew more about every house than the house itself. It was not true. It was worse: she knew the same, but she knew it filed.

"Dona Amparo," said the Keeper, as if she had been expecting her, which was impossible and always seemed so.

Amparo laid out the business in the order of Vera's sheet: the certificate for the house, the power of attorney, the records for the notary. The Keeper heard it all without writing anything

down, rose, disappeared among the shelves and came back with three great books with worn spines, which she set on the desk with the care with which one sets down living things.

"The house is easy," she said. "The records take longer, for your family gives work to trace. Let us go in order. For the power of attorney, you need your own. But for the old partitions of the house of the Olive Press we must go further back, to your grandmother's time. May I?"

And she went further back. And what happened in the hour that followed, Amparo never knew whether the Keeper did it by trade or by something else, because the Keeper never commented, never joined the sentences it was not her office to join: she confined herself to opening the books, marking the lines with her finger, reading aloud what was written. But the order in which she opened them, the patience with which she left each page open exactly long enough, that nobody had prescribed, and Amparo would always remember that hour the way one remembers a consultation deeper than the doctor's.

The Keeper's finger stopped first at an old entry, the ink gone brown.

"Faustino, of the house of the Olive Press. Your grandmother's brother." She read without haste: the birth, and directly after it, because the books waste no time, the death. "Unmarried. No declared occupation. Deceased in his sister's house, aged sixty-one." The finger lingered on the final line. "Your grandmother requested this death record three times. People sometimes request the papers of their dead more than once. Each Keeper passes it on to the next: whoever asks for the same paper three times does not need the paper. They need something else."

She turned pages. Another book, another ink.

"Amadeu, of the house of the Olive Press." Amparo straightened in her chair without knowing it. The Keeper read as she had read the other, in the same exact tone, no warmer and no colder: "Brother of Custódia, of Glória and of Amparo. Unmarried. No declared occupation. Deceased in the house that was his mother's, aged fifty-eight." A pause. "Your mother never came to request this one. She was no longer here. Your sister Custódia requested it. Once only."

And then, changing nothing in her voice, not lifting her eyes from the book, the Keeper turned a few pages more and read the third name.

"Salvo. Son of Fortunato and of Amparo." Her finger on the baptism line, in the round hand of another Keeper, from thirty-six years ago. "Unmarried. Occupation: whatever offers." She raised her eyes then, and her eyes were like Justo's at the warehouse forty years before: they did not judge, and for that very reason there was nowhere to hide from them. "This one has only one line open so far, dona Amparo. The others are not yet written."

The three books lay open on the desk, side by side, and Amparo looked at them and saw what it was impossible not to see, what perhaps no woman of the family had ever seen like this, all together, black on white, with dates: three men of the same house, in three generations, seated on the same line of the books. Unmarried. No occupation. Deceased in the house of a woman of the family. And beside each of them, invisible in the records and plain as ink, the woman who had held him: the great-grandmother who requested Faustino's death paper three times, the mother who never came to request Amadeu's, and she, Amparo, with Salvo's line still almost entirely unwritten.

"The records do not judge," said the Keeper, closing the two old books with the same living care. "They register. But there are families in which the entries rhyme, and the rhyme is seen bet-

ter from here than from the houses. You came to deal with the papers of your house." She pushed the new book, Salvo's, half a hand's width aside, exactly as Benvinda pushed the ledger. "Those will be ready this week. And yours, dona Amparo? Your own papers, who deals with those?"

Amparo opened her mouth to say that hers were these, that it was all the same thing, and stopped. Because it was not. The house, the power of attorney, the partitions: all of that was her life in the service of others, what would remain for whoever remained. And then, without having planned it, she heard herself ask for a thing that was not on Vera's sheet of points, that served no notary, that had no possible use:

"I want a copy of my record. Mine. The birth one."

The Keeper did not ask what for. Perhaps that was, in the end, the true art of her office: knowing which questions are not asked. She rose, went to the shelves, came back with the right book, found the page and, before copying, read aloud, in the exact tone of always, as she had read the men:

"Amparo, of the house of the Olive Press. Born in the year of the Great Winter, daughter of..." and she read it all, the parents, the date told by events, the old hand, and Amparo heard her own beginning read by a voice from outside, in that room smelling of wax, and it was like hearing herself be born: before she was anyone's mother, before she was anyone's widow, before she was sister, daughter, saint, before the hands, there had been a girl with a name, entered in a book, with the whole of life still to write.

The Keeper copied the record out by hand, in her upright script, stamped it, folded the paper in four and passed it to her across the desk.

"Most people," she said, and it was the nearest she came to a comment in the whole afternoon, "only ask for this paper when they need it to deal with the others! You are the third, in all my years, to ask for it for itself." She gathered the books into her arms, the way one gathers sleepy children. "The other two changed their lives. But it may have been coincidence."

She did not go straight home. Her feet took her, unconsulted, along the eastern slope, to the cemetery, where she had not been since the day of the dead. Her mother's grave and

Amadeu's lay side by side, in the family's old way, and Amparo found herself before them with her hands already moving, because that was what she had always done there: pulling the weeds, straightening the jar, scrubbing the stone, serving the dead as she served the living. This time she ordered the hands to stop. It cost them, and her. She stood still before the two stones, hands crossed over her apron, and tidied nothing, and said nothing, and let herself simply be there, with them, in the warm wind of summer's end. To her mother, after a while, she said inwardly what there was to say, which was little and was everything: you did what you knew. I am going to try to do what you could not have known. To her brother she said nothing. On her brother's stone she laid her hand, a moment, the way one lays a hand on a shoulder, man to man, fall to fall. And on her way out she passed, as she always passed, the corner plot of the little angels, and slowed, as the whole village slowed there, that slower step being the only prayer those small ones ever received, and went on.

Then she walked down home with the paper folded in four in her coat pocket, on the left side, where in winter she carried the month's money. It weighed the same as nothing, and she felt it the whole way, as if she carried in her pocket a small ember, or

a seed, or both, which were perhaps the same thing. At home, she did not put it in the pantry, nor in the drawer of papers, nor in Vera's blue folder. She put it in the bedroom, on the chest of drawers, leaning against the portrait of Fortunato, where she could see it from the bed.

"Say nothing," she told the portrait.

And the portrait, as had been its custom these six winters, said nothing, in the tenderest way that nothing can be said.

7. The great fall

Autumn came in with mild rains, and for a few weeks it seemed life had decided to take hope's side.

Salvo was doing better. It was not his mother's wishful eye: it was the shop that said so, and the shop was never wrong. Twice that month, Benvinda had told Amparo, eyebrows high, that Salvo had come in, bought, and paid. Paid on the spot, from his own wallet, conversation and all. He had brought the rent up to date with the landlady; it was known. He had paid cousin Henrique back; that was known too, because in Véspera payments made as much noise as debts. He was away in the big town many days at a stretch, said he had picked up some jobs there, big odd jobs, good ones, and when he turned up at his mother's he came with small presents, the good coffee, a shawl, and with a new hurry about him, the restlessness of a man with plans he is not telling.

"You'll see, Mother," he said to her one afternoon, at the door, with a shine on him she had not seen since he was a boy. "You'll see. This time it's me putting all the accounts straight. All of

them. You'll be a month not knowing what to do with your hands."

She should have heard the warning inside the shine. All her life she had heard it; her ear was tuned to falls the way the old women of the serra are tuned to rain; and this time, precisely this time, she chose not to. She was tired of divining disasters. The doctor had told her to sleep, Vera had told her to let go, the paper folded in four waited on the chest of drawers, and her son was paying his debts and smiling. Amparo decided to believe. It was the luxury she allowed herself, one month of believing, and she never regretted it, even afterwards, because it was in that month that she learned what resting would be like, and at least she came to know the taste.

The fall came on a Thursday night, by telephone, and announced itself in the first word.

"Mother."

That was all. But Salvo had a thousand ways of saying Mother, and Amparo knew them every one: the sung Mother of requests, the round Mother of feasts, the quick Mother of hurries. This was none of them. This one came bare, with no trimming at all,

the voice underneath it trembling like her hand in the pantry, and Amparo felt the kitchen floor tilt, like the garden that morning, only this time the world did not right itself.

"Where are you?"

"In the big town. Mother, I need..." The word caught crosswise in him. In thirty-six years, Salvo had never said it. He laid his wants on the table, took all the roundabout ways, waited for her hands to do the rest, but to ask, to ask with his mouth, never. If he was asking, the fear was bigger than the habit. "I need you to come here. Tonight. I'll explain everything, but it has to be tonight, before they close it. I'm at the café by the old station. Mother..." and the voice broke in half, and out of the middle came the rest: "don't bring everything, but bring what you have."

Amparo hung up and stood one second unmoving in the dark hallway. One second only. Then her body did what it had been trained for all its life, what it knew how to do better than any other body in the village: it set itself in motion without panic. The hands dressed her, went to the flour tin, counted without trembling, folded the money in four, pinned it into the inside pocket of her coat. Her head, cold, made the list: not the neigh-

bour, who talks; not Custódia, who sees; the boy from the house below, the one with the car who works shifts, he'll drive me and hold his tongue.

And that is how Amparo, at sixty-three, did for the first time in her life a thing she had never done: she knocked on someone's door at night to ask.

"I need you to take me to the big town, lad. Now. I'll pay the petrol and the trouble."

The boy asked nothing, and she wished him well forever for it. Half an hour of road in the dark, the headlamps opening the way through fine rain, and Amparo upright in the seat, bag on her lap, looking straight ahead. With every kilometre there came to her, unbidden, Vera's voice on the telephone months before: one of these days your hands will come down on him with everything they carry. Well, here they went, the hands, along the road through the rain, inside a coat with a pin in it. On their way to catch him once again.

On the road through the dark, Amparo did what she did before all great things: she rehearsed. It was the habit of a lifetime, itself rehearsed through a thousand eves: the right words for the

teacher, for the creditor, for the notary, for the landlady. She set the sentences in a row, measured them, trimmed their fat, and by the time she arrived, the conversation had already been held inside her and all that remained was to say it aloud. She rehearsed figures, deadlines, the order of her arguments. And in the middle of the rehearsal she caught herself thinking a thing from outside the script, an intruder question that came in through the car window like the cold: and if I did not know how to do this? The women whose sons do not fall, the ones who never learned this midnight trade, what do they do on nights like this? They sleep, she answered herself. They are asleep at this hour, in the happy ignorance of those who never needed to know how one talks to a moneylender. The skill I am carrying in this car is not a gift. It is a scar with practice. And it was with that thought, not the rehearsed ones, that she walked into the café.

The café by the old station was a long, half-empty place, with too much light at the counter and too little at the tables. Salvo was at the far end, and Amparo saw him from the door and had to put strength into her legs, because her son was sitting in the corner, against the wall, both hands around an empty glass, smaller than she had seen him since the night of the cord. At the

table with him were two men. A young one, in a good jacket, who worked at his phone and never once looked up. And an older one, dry, shirt buttoned to the top, who worked at nothing: he simply sat, hands quiet one upon the other on the table, and it was by the hands that Amparo knew at once which of the two commanded. In the big town they called him the Quiet Man, she learned afterwards. He lent money to those the banks would not lend to, and he had no need to raise his voice, because his silence did the whole of the work.

"You are the mother," said the Quiet Man when she sat down. It was not a question.

The story, Amparo heard twice: first in the Quiet Man's version, short as a receipt, and then, through the night, in her son's version, long as all his versions. They came to the same. Salvo had gone into a deal with an acquaintance from the site: a big load of building material, bought cheap from a firm closing down in the south, to be sold on at double to the contractors of the region. A sure thing, Mother, dead sure, all it took was being there with the money ahead of the others. He did not have the money. The Quiet Man did. The material, paid for and loaded, had been seized halfway with all its papers wrong, for the closing firm no

longer owned what it sold, and the acquaintance from the site had known it, and had vanished with his share to parts unknown. The debt remained. The debt had interest that doubled month on month, in the Quiet Man's fashion, and the first month fell due that night.

And in the middle of the disaster, in the middle of the long café, Amparo heard the part that took the rest of her strength, because it was the part that hurt most and explained most. The reason. Salvo with his head down, turning the empty glass, speaking low, for her only:

"I wanted to pay you everything back, Mother. That was the whole point of it. I'd put it together in a month and come to your house with an envelope, see? An envelope of mine. I'd set it on your table and count it out in front of you, note by note, the way you did to me." And he laughed, a laugh that was the inside-out of a laugh. "I wanted to see your face. That was all I wanted, to see your face."

Amparo's hands lay quiet on the table while her heart went falling down through her body. So that was it. The money counted out in the winter, the new question, the announced notebook, everything she had done as a first gesture of letting him grow,

he had received as a humiliation to be avenged. Not out of malice: out of reading. Her son knew no other way to read. In a whole life where love had always arrived in the form of rescue, a limit could only mean love withdrawn, and at the first wound of that withdrawal he had run to perform the only heroism he knew: one stroke of luck to put everything back in its place, himself on top, the debt wiped, his mother proud. The world of the men of that family, Amparo understood there, in that café, was this: either the lap, or the great deed. Of the middle ground, where life is actually lived, the middle that is working and failing and paying little by little, of that middle nobody had ever told them.

And then Amparo did what she had come to do. The book will not pretend she did not.

She negotiated. She sat up straight, asked the man with the phone for paper and a pen, and negotiated with the Quiet Man coldly, figure by figure, for forty minutes. She did not ask for the debt's forgiveness, having understood at once there was none; she did not invoke her age, nor her widowhood, nor her son sitting there beside her, because she saw in the man's quiet eyes that none of that had a price. She offered facts: a down payment

that night, in cash, what she carried in the inside pocket; a schedule of payments with dates, written out there, signed; and her word, Amparo's, of the house of the Olive Press of Véspera, which the Quiet Man could send to be verified wherever he liked. He did send, in fact: he made two calls in a low voice, from the back of the café, and came back with another face, because the market, whatever market it was, had confirmed what the whole village knew: that woman's word always paid.

Halfway through, the Quiet Man tried her once, in his fashion, without raising his voice. He looked at Salvo, who sat beside his mother as if he were seven years old again, and said, slowly, to her: you ought to charge him interest as well. I would, in your place. A man of this age still bringing his mother to my tables. And he waited, hands quiet, to see what she would do with it, because it was a test, Amparo saw that at once: the man was measuring whom he was closing with. She did not look at her son. She answered the Quiet Man to his face, in his own register, without acid: what I charge my son, and how, is the business of my house, and my house is not at this table. At this table there is a debt and a schedule. Do you want the money or the conversa-

tion? And the Quiet Man made with his mouth a minimal movement which in such a man was a burst of laughter, and drew the paper to himself, and signed too.

"You understand," he said, putting away the down payment and the signed paper, "that the one who owes from tonight is you. Your son, to me, has ceased to exist. It is your word I hold."

"It is my word you hold," said Amparo.

And as she said it, she saw herself. As in the kitchen, as in the garden: from outside. She saw a woman of sixty-three, admirable, straight as a roof-beam, performing with absolute mastery a thing she had been performing for thirty-six years, and she saw, with the same sharpness, what the mastery was: practice. Nobody is born knowing how to negotiate with moneylenders at midnight. It is learned. She had had a whole life of lessons, and every lesson had been a fall of his, and the perfection of that hour was the exact measure of the size of their prison, both of theirs. The pride and the horror arrived together, hand in hand, and Amparo received them together, because she knew by now that this was how truth came: whole, with both its sides.

The drive back was made in silence. The shift boy in front, quiet as promised; behind, mother and son, side by side, watching the rain. Halfway home, Salvo felt for her hand in the dark, as he had as a small boy, and Amparo gave it to him, because there were things that stood above all the learnings, and she held her son's big hand all the way to Véspera, and above his relief she kept thinking, with a calm that frightened her: this is the last time this hand seeks mine like this. It cannot be like this again.

She put him to sleep in the room that had been his, because letting him go back alone to the river street in that state was out of the question. The boy's room stood as it had always stood; Amparo had never unmade rooms. Salvo fell onto the narrow bed dressed, and was asleep before she turned off the light, a deep and instant sleep, the sleep of the pardoned.

Amparo stayed.

She stood in the light from the hallway, looking at the enormous man folded into the small bed, and her right hand, alone, under no order at all, made the old movement: it lowered itself slowly onto his chest, seeking the breath. Her body knew that gesture better than any other: one entire year of nights, thirty-six years of echoes. She felt her son's chest rise and fall, strong, regular,

alive, safe as his name, and she stood there with her hand resting, taking her leave. Because that, she understood, was what the hand was doing, ahead of her, as always: it was taking its leave.

"Sleep," she said, very low, to the son who could not hear her. "That was the last one, Salvo. I won't hold you like this anymore. I am going to learn another way, and you are going to have to learn it with me."

And she took the hand away.

It was the hardest thing she did in that whole night, harder than the road, harder than the Quiet Man, harder than the pin in the coat: lifting her hand off her sleeping son's chest and carrying it away with her, empty, out of the room.

In the morning, Salvo appeared in the kitchen late and slow, in yesterday's clothes with his shame worn over them, and could not look at her. He sat in the corner, picked at the bread without taking it, twice rehearsed a Mother, I that went nowhere. Amparo set his coffee in front of him and did not help him out of it, because she had learned by now that there are silences that belong to other people and must not be swept. At last it was he:

I'll pay back what I can. Truly. And she: I know. And he, lower, eyes on his coffee: you must be ashamed of me. And Amparo put down the cloth, and looked at the enormous man shrunk into the boy's chair, and answered him with the only thing she had whole that morning, which was the truth: ashamed I was last night, at that man's table, and it passed on the road home. What I have today is not shame, Salvo. It is a question that won't leave me: how is it that you, at thirty-six, still do not know that you could have come to me at the very start, with no deal, no great deed, just to say: Mother, I'm in trouble? Why is it, in this family, easier to owe a moneylender than to say I'm in trouble in good time? Think about that on your way to the site. And go to work, for shame works well.

And he went. And Amparo watched him down the path in the grey light, and then sat in the kitchen with the flour tin and counted what was left. She did not cry while she counted; counting, she never cried; numbers dry everything. What was left she wrote in the pantry notebook, under all the other lines, and looked at the figure a long time. It was not enough. For the life she herself had, it was enough and to spare, for she had always needed little. But for the trade she had plied until that night, the trade of net, of ground, of a hand held out beneath a

man falling from ever higher up, it was not enough. The tin had a bottom after all. Thirty-six years dropping stones into water, and the truth was this, round, in figures, under the kitchen light: the next fall could no longer be paid for.

Outside it was beginning to pale. Amparo closed the notebook, put the tin away, and before lying down went to the bedroom for the paper folded in four that leaned against the portrait. She opened it and read it at the window, in the first light: Amparo, of the house of the Olive Press, born in the year of the Great Winter. The whole of life still to write, the Keeper had said.

"Well then," she said to the girl in the record. "Let us see what you can still do."

8. The whole ledger

The news of the night in the big town did not get out in Véspera. It was one of the few, in Amparo's life, that did not, perhaps because the shift boy held his tongue, perhaps because the big town lay beyond the reach of the small town's ears. But Benvinda knew there was something. Benvinda always knew there was something, by the simplest method in the world: she stood at the counter. Everything passed through there, and what did not pass was missed, and the missing showed too.

"You haven't been in to pay the usual this month," she said one afternoon, when Amparo came through the shop door. "It's the twenty-second."

"I haven't, no," said Amparo. "And that is what I've come to talk to you about. But it's not counter talk."

Benvinda looked at her a moment, read her face as she read the ledger, and did a thing she had not done since her father's funeral: she closed the shop before its hour. She turned the sign, ran the bolt, put out the window light, and took Amparo behind the counter, into the tiny back room where there were two

chairs, a small stove and forty years of paperwork. She made coffee for them both, her way, strong as a blow, and sat down facing her friend, hands in her lap, waiting.

Amparo told her everything.

She had not planned to tell everything. She had planned the essentials: the new rule, the request. But the back room was small and warm, the coffee was strong, and Benvinda listened as nobody in the village listened, without haste and without astonishment, and the story came out whole: the telephone, the road in the rain, the café by the old station, the Quiet Man and his still hands, the down payment, the signed schedule, her son's sentence about the envelope, and at last the kitchen at dawn, the tin, the figure that was not enough. Benvinda heard it to the end without touching her coffee. Then she got up without a word, disappeared into the storeroom, and Amparo heard her moving heavy things, and when she came back she was carrying in her arms, wrapped in a cloth that had once been a sugar sack, a thick book with black covers, full of dust.

"Your month is still there to be crossed out," said Benvinda, unwrapping the book with care. "But before we speak of your ledger, I want to show you my father's. Forty years this has been

in the storeroom and I never showed it to a living soul. I think it was waiting for you, this book."

The back room was the size of a pantry and held the whole shop in another order: the invoices of forty years in bundles tied with string, the broken scale nobody would throw away, the calendar of the year her father died, stopped at May, hanging beside this year's calendar, which Benvinda had never explained to anyone and did not need to: May was the month the man had dropped right there, behind the counter, apron on, halfway through putting half a kilo of sugar on credit for a customer. He died as he lived, his daughter used to say, giving without receiving, and she said it as praise, and only on this night, in this conversation, did Amparo hear her say it another way, slower, like someone tasting the sentence for the first time from the inside: he died extending credit, Amparo. The last thing my father did in this world was write down a debt he was never going to collect.

Her father's ledger was the same as hers and belonged to another world: the paper yellower, the prices in another way of speaking, the cramped hand of a man who economised on everything, even ink. Benvinda opened it at a page marked with a dry straw, turned it towards Amparo, and pointed.

"Read."

Amparo put on her glasses. The page had a name at its head, as they all did: Amadeu, house of the Olive Press. And it went down, line by line, year by year, in a debtor's script she knew as well as her own: the tobacco, the wine, the tins, the small daily credit of a man who lived at the corner of the table. And in among the lines, every few months, always the same, a note in the old man's cramped hand: paid by the mother. Paid by the mother. Paid by the mother. Twenty years of page. The last line did not say paid. It said, in the father's already shaking hand, one word only: forgiven.

"It was when your mother died," said Benvinda, low. "My father called me back here, I was young, and said: this one we cross out for good, for the one who paid it is gone, and to collect it from the dead man who owes it would be a sin twice over. And he crossed it out, and it was never spoken of again. Your brother never knew how much he owed, Amparo. Never, in twenty years. The account was always settled when he came in, and he thought it was his luck, or our forgetfulness, or our liking for

him. He died without ever seeing this page. So now you tell me, for I never had the courage to ask it of anyone: did we do him a kindness?"

Amparo looked at the page a long time. Paid by the mother, twenty years, and at the end, forgiven, which was the same thing in other words: paid by everyone except himself. How is a man to grow like that, she thought, and said it:

"It was no kindness. It was a chain-gang. Each of us held our own bar of it thinking we were holding up the roof." She raised her eyes to her friend. "My mother paid, your father hid, the village said poor soul, and Amadeu in the middle of it all, never once touching the true size of his own life with his own hand. He died not knowing what it cost to exist. We knew it for him. Look at that inheritance, Benvinda. Look at love so badly delivered."

They sat silent. The little stove had gone out and neither rose to light it. Outside someone passed, tried the shop door, was puzzled, went away. The world could wait.

"I came to ask you something," said Amparo, at last. "I came to ask you not to cross out anything more of Salvo's without his knowing. The twenty-second is over. If he owes, let him owe:

with his name on the page, with the figures in plain sight, and let it be him you go to for the money, with your head up, the way one asks a man. And if he doesn't pay, let it stand owing, and let it hurt, and let it be known. I know what I am asking you. I am asking you to let my son fall in front of you without putting out your hand. You, who have been my friend fifty years. I know no bigger request."

Benvinda stirred her cold coffee, slowly, and when she answered she did not answer the request. She answered something that came from deeper down, something Amparo had never heard from that mouth in half a century of friendship:

"Do you know why I never collected from anyone, Amparo? Everyone thinks it's goodness. My goodness is as famous as your sainthood; we make a fine pair of photographs." She laughed without laughing, that laugh that was kin to all the laughs without laughter of that winter. "I don't collect because I'm afraid. I always was. My father said a shop that collects loses its friends, and I built my whole life on that sentence, and the truth underneath the sentence is this: I believe, deep down, since I was a girl, that if I collect what I am owed, people will stop liking me. That my place in this village is paid for in credit.

That the day I am just, I will be alone. Look hard at the two of us, Amparo. Fifty years sitting at the two ends of the same counter, each chained to her own end of the same rope. You believing love is paying. Me believing love is never asking. And the ledger in the middle, poor thing, taking all our fears down in account-book script."

Amparo was quiet a moment, because she had just seen, and seeing takes its time. Her friend was right and more right than she knew: they were the two ends of the same rope, and there was a third end, and a fourth; the rope went all the way round the village. Graça paying for her place with services, Plácida who never asked for anything, Soledade up on the heights with her own cistern, every house in Véspera with its own way of believing that love is paid for, earned, served, endured, everything except the simple way, the impossible one: that love is received.

"Then we do it like this," said Amparo, and she put her hand out across the little table, across Amadeu's old ledger, and it was a negotiating hand, the same one from the big town, but what travelled in it was new. "I stop paying what I do not owe. You start collecting what you are owed. I let my son feel his own weight, and you let the village like you with the accounts in or-

der, and we shall both see what falls and what, after all, holds up by itself. And when one of us weakens, and we shall both weaken, for this is not unlearned in two weeks, the other one closes the shop before its hour and makes a coffee like this one of yours, like a blow. Agreed?"

Benvinda looked at her friend's outstretched hand. And shook it, slowly and hard, the way one signs.

"Agreed." And at once, being of the shop, for the shop formalises everything: "But this deserves an entry."

She rose, fetched the current ledger, and opened it at Salvo's page. The page stood as Amparo had left it in the winter: crossed out from top to bottom, in a graveyard peace. Benvinda took the pencil from behind her ear, and below all the crossings-out, on the first clean line, she wrote in her round hand, aloud, word by word, so that her friend would hear the size of what they were doing:

"Salvo, house on the river street. New account, opened to the man himself." And she added, in the remarks column, the date, and this, which Amparo carried home with her like a key: "Payable by the holder."

They both looked at the written line. It was a shopkeeper's line, in a credit ledger in a small village, three words and a date. And it was, they both knew without saying it, the first line of a different story: the first time, in three generations and two ledgers, that a man of that family would owe in his own name.

And because real pacts are baptised at once, right there, Benvinda wanted to practise. There was an old account of the contractor's wife's, seventeen parcels over two years, never paid and never mentioned, and she decided, with the courage of eight in the evening, that she would raise the matter on Monday. What was missing was the how. And the two women in their sixties spent the next half hour in the back room rehearsing one sentence, like schoolgirls learning a lesson: Benvinda standing behind an imaginary counter, Amparo playing the customer, and the sentence coming out crooked every time, or too pleading, or too dry, or with a discount already built into its tail. Say it again, Amparo ordered. Dona Eduvina, while you happen to be here... no, that's apologising. Again. Dona Eduvina, your account stands at so much. Would you like to bring it up to date? And at the seventh or eighth try one came out straight, simple, without a gram of guilt, and the two of them were so astonished at the

sound of it that they laughed out loud, in the back room, behind the closed shop, a girls' laugh that nobody in Véspera had heard from either of them in forty years.

"God grant he pays," said Benvinda, closing the ledger.

"God grant," said Amparo. "And if he doesn't pay, Benvinda, look: let it be written. Let it at least be written, this time, whose account it was."

Benvinda's first collection took place the following Monday, as promised, and Véspera talked of it for a week, and the book tells it because it belongs to this story as much as the flour tin does. The contractor's wife came into the shop at her usual hour, asked for her usual things, and as she was leaving with her parcels, Benvinda, both hands set on the counter to stop them running away, said the rehearsed sentence. It came out straight, by all accounts, better than in any rehearsal: dona Eduvina, your account stands at so much. Would you like to bring it up to date? And there fell upon the shop, the witnesses related, a silence of the world's end, for it was generations since anyone had heard that house ask for what was its own. The contractor's wife stood a moment not knowing on which shelf to put her face, then coloured, then laughed nervously, and said of course, cer-

tainly, she had hardly noticed the account had grown so, which was a lie, and everyone knew it was a lie, and no one made anything of it, for exits too should be left clean. She paid it all, there, from her purse. And at the door, recovered, she did what people of her sort do to remount the throne: she turned and said, loudly, to the shop at large, you are modernising, dona Benvinda. And Benvinda, from the counter, answered with the placidity of the just the sentence that travelled the whole village by supertime and entered the speech of Véspera for good: it is not modernising, dona Eduvina. It is only that my father's shop gave credit, and mine sells. It took us two generations to notice the difference.

At night she telephoned Amparo to tell her, and the two of them were half an hour on the line like two girls after a first dance, repeating the details, imitating the voices, laughing. And in the middle of the laughter Benvinda said, suddenly serious: do you know what I felt, when she paid? I thought I was going to feel shame, or lose the customer, or whatever it was my father taught me to fear. I felt none of it. I felt the counter grow taller, Amparo. I swear it to you. As if the whole shop had risen a hand's width under my feet. And Amparo, from her dark hallway, with her mother's telephone in her hand, smiled and said

yes, she knew it, that it was exactly the height one comes up to when one stops paying for one's place: the right height. Our own.

She left by the back door, on that first night of the pact, the front one being bolted already, and crossed the square at the end of the afternoon. Passing the dry fountain she slowed, as she had slowed there all her life without ever knowing why, and looked at the silent spout, at the empty basin with autumn leaves in its bottom. As a child, her grandmother used to tell her the fountain had run dry from giving so much, and said it as praise, as example: she gave to her last drop, our fountain. Amparo stood a moment, in that low light, looking at the example of her whole life set there in stone in the middle of the square, dry for three generations, with the entire village fetching its water from the serra.

"You gave to your last drop," she told it. "And now you give nothing."

And she went home to make the soup, because the soup, that was hers, and there was a difference; she was learning it: between giving oneself away to the last drop, and feeding the peo-

ple one loves for the pleasure of watching them eat. The fountain never knew it. She was still in time.

9. The bottom

The great rains came early that year. The river Fundo rose to its accustomed marks and stayed there, thinking, like an animal that has not yet decided, and the village entered its November of closed doors. On the river street, the building work stopped: nobody lays brick under water. For the men of the sites, the great rains were the oldest arithmetic in the world: short week, short wages.

And the Quiet Man's instalment knew nothing of rain.

Salvo appeared on a night of wind, soaked from the road, his distress already fully organised into figures. This was what he was truly good at, Amparo thought as she watched him spread the sums on the kitchen table, the table of always: organising distress in order to hand it over. He was short two-thirds of the instalment. The site stopped, the week cut, and the deadline was four days off, and the Quiet Man doesn't play games, Mother, you heard the man, you know how that is.

"I know," said Amparo. "I sat at his table. I know better than you."

"Then you understand." Relief crossed his face like a breath of air; he was already stowing the problem on the far side, on her side. "It's just this one. I swear, Mother. With the site running, I'm straight by January. It's just this one bridge that needs making."

The word served her as she had never known a word could serve. A bridge. That was what was being asked of her, once again: that she lay herself down full length over the water, as she had done all her life, so that her son could cross over without wetting his feet. And on the other side of the table, under her apron, her hands were already moving, already knew by heart the way to the pantry, the shelf, the tin, and Amparo gripped one in the other with all the strength she had, and made them stay.

"No, Salvo."

He did not understand at once. That was what hurt her most, afterwards, going back over the night: the time the no took to arrive. Her son sat looking at her with the face of a man who has misheard, and she had to say it again, slowly, in the gentlest voice she could find, for gentleness was what remained when the rescue was taken out:

"My word to the Quiet Man was for the schedule, and the schedule will not fail: if in four days the money is not all there, I cover what is missing, because a word given is a word given, and mine is good. But it will be after you have done everything, everything, Salvo, and this time everything is not coming here. The instalment is yours. The problem is yours. And you are more able than anyone ever let you find out. Sit down, eat, and think with me if you like: what can you do in four days?"

"What can I do?" He laughed, and the laugh was no longer a shield; it was a blade, turned inward and outward at once. "You're talking like Vera now. Was it she who put this into your head? Or the new doctor, or whoever it was. You were never like this."

"I wasn't. And look where that put the two of us."

"Put us where?" He stood up; the chair scraped on the floor; and here it came, she felt it coming the way one feels thunder, the thing that had never come: the true anger, the one from underneath, the one with thirty-six years of floor to it. "Go on, say it: put us where? I always paid everything! Sooner or later everything always got paid in this family!" And then it came out, flung all at once, the sentence that stayed ringing in the kitchen like

broken crockery: "You never once let me fall in my whole life. Not once! Why start now, when I'm desperate? What kind of mother learns to be a mother backwards at sixty?"

The silence that followed was the size of the house.

And Amparo, inside the silence, did the hardest thing in the whole book so far: nothing. She did not answer the blade, did not correct the account, did not say the easy truth, which was nothing ever got paid, it was me, always, and which would have won the argument and lost everything else. She sat still, hands gripped beneath her apron, looking at her desperate, furious son, and let his sentence exist, whole, in the air of the kitchen, because the sentence, being unjust, was exact. It was the most exact thing Salvo had ever said about their two lives. She had never let him fall. Not once. And here they were.

"Eat your soup," was what she said. "It's getting cold."

He did not eat. He pulled on his wet coat with a boy's gestures, the kind through which the child shows inside the fury, and at the door he turned, hand already on the latch, for the parting thrust, the one he had always known where to land:

"If anything happens to me, it's on you."

And he went out into the rain.

A house, after a door slams, has a sound it has at no other hour: the sound of everything left unsaid settling on the furniture like dust. Amparo sat listening to it. On the table his soup cooled untouched, the spoon beside it, and she did not clear it: she left it there all night, deliberately, the way one leaves a light on, because to clear the plate was to close the night and she did not want the night closed; she wanted it open, in case he came back. He did not come back. By midnight the soup was a cold thing with a skin, and Amparo lifted it at last and ate it herself, cold as it was, standing at the kitchen counter, not quite knowing why, or knowing: because it was his and one does not throw food away, and because something of that night had to be swallowed whole, and better the soup than the rest.

What followed, nobody saw, and the book must tell it because it was there that the crossing was made or lost: Amparo's hours alone in the house with his sentence nailed to the door. She did not sleep. She walked. Kitchen to hallway, hallway to bedroom, bedroom to kitchen, the wind rattling the windows, and twice, twice, she came to herself in the pantry with no memory of go-

ing there, her hand on the way to the high shelf. The first time, she turned back on the strength of the washing tank, of Custódia's voice: who caught him the last time, when Mother was no longer here? The second time, in the small hours, the strength came from nowhere; it had all been spent; and what saved her was the telephone, ringing at the exact hour, as if someone were keeping watch, and someone was, for it was Vera.

"Mother. He rang me, asking. I said no." A pause, and the sound of a long breath, the breath of a woman folding her sheets away inside. "I'm ringing to know how you are."

And Amparo, for the first time in her life, at the third stroke of a crisis's midnight, told her daughter the truth:

"I am holding on to the pantry door, child. For two hours I have done nothing in this world except not go to the tin."

On the other end there was a silence different from every silence there had ever been between them. Then Vera's voice came, and it came changed, came without numbered points, came hoarse:

"Stay where you are, Mother. Stay holding on. I know it costs." And quietly, almost laughing and almost crying: "Look at the two of us. Thirty years quarrelling, and it turns out this is all I wanted: to be on the telephone with you while you don't go to the tin." And then, grave: "He'll come through, Mother. Hear what I'm telling you. You've just never seen him come through, because you never gave him the time. You always arrived first."

They stayed on the line until the hens, talking of nothing, of the rain, of Vera's boy, of a recipe, of the time Fortunato could make the chestnuts last till March. When they hung up there was light behind the serra, and the flour tin stood in its place, closed, untouched, and Amparo slept three hours of stone sleep with the telephone beside the bed like a held hand.

The four days that followed were the longest of her life, and Véspera, not knowing what it measured, measured them out for her.

On the first day Custódia appeared with a pretext in her hand, a bunch of cabbage to trade for seeds, as if seeds couldn't wait. She sat, drank her coffee, watched her sister over the rim of the cup through half an hour of no conversation at all, and on her way out, at the gate, said only, without looking back: you are do-

ing right. And that it costs like everything, I know that too. If you need company for doing nothing, I'll do nothing with you. And off she went, upright and shut as ever, and Amparo stood at the gate slowly understanding that she had just received, from the sentinel, the greatest declaration of love her sister was capable of.

That same evening Glória rang, and Glória came in the role of her life, anxious and sweet, all bridges: that the boy had rung Henrique, that Henrique this time said no because his wife wouldn't have it, poor thing, she's the one who rules that roost, and that maybe, Amparo, maybe the two of us could, just between ourselves, only this once, the poor people's feast is next week and the boy without his motorbike... And Amparo heard her middle sister out to the end, with true tenderness, because Glória was the family's heart speaking, she always had been, and answered her slowly, with the gentlest words she could find: Glória. You love him, I know. But look at what you are proposing to me: that I rescue him in secret and call it love. I did that for thirty-six years, sister. Do you know how he thanked me? He fell from higher up. Not this time. And if he rings you, tell him

no in that sweet voice of yours, for you he forgives at once. You'll see, he survives the no. It is one of the most survivable things there are, the no. It's just that we never let him try it.

On the second day, it was known at the shop that Salvo had sold the motorbike. To the contractor's son, who had been after it for a year, and for less than it was worth, for haste has its price. Amparo took the news standing in the middle of the shop with the bag of rice in her hand, and had to set the bag down. The motorbike. He would walk to the sites now, but the motorbike was his vanity, the man's toy, the Sunday rides. Benvinda, from the counter, looked at her over her glasses, and in the look went the warning of their pact: not a word, not a gesture, let it be.

On the third day, it was known he had gone to the big town. With the shift boy, it was said, and Amparo smiled inwardly at the irony: the same car, the same road in the rain, another passenger.

On the fourth day, nothing was known, and it was the worst of all. Nothing, Amparo discovered that day, is the heaviest news there is: the others arrive and settle; nothing hangs in the air all day, unsettled. She made bread so as to make nothing else, because bread was the trade that asked the most of hands and left

the head least free, and while she kneaded she remembered Fortunato, who kneaded with her on Saturdays in the early years, sleeves rolled, saying that the secret of bread was the same as the secret of children: work it well and then leave it in peace, covered, somewhere warm, without poking at it, for it rises on its own, and whoever lifts the cloth every hour to see if it has grown only manages to make sure it doesn't. Forty years later, hands in the dough, Amparo laughed alone in the kitchen, a small wet laugh. The man had told her everything, after all. He had told it to her in flour, in Saturday language, and she had heard recipes where the map was.

She kneaded, shaped, covered the loaves with the blankets, and lifted no cloth before its hour.

At the end of the afternoon, when she had already scrubbed what was not dirty and watered what was not thirsty, there was a knock at the door, and it was the shift boy, drenched, with a folded paper in his hand.

"Your son asked me to bring you this, dona Amparo. And to say it's all settled."

It was the schedule paper, the one from the café by the old station, the one she had signed beneath the Quiet Man's figures. On the line of the first instalment someone had written, in a hand that was not hers, a single word, with the date: paid. And underneath, smaller, crooked, written in haste or in shame, came the rest, and Amparo read it right there, at the door, with the rain beating on the porch roof, and read it a hundred times more that winter:

This one was me. Tell Vera she doesn't have to like me yet. Just tell her I've begun.

It did not say Mother, asked for nothing, promised nothing. It was the poorest note her son had ever written her, and it was the first that was entirely his. Amparo thanked the boy, shut the door, sat down on the kitchen chair with the paper in her hand, and let her body, at last, do what it had been asking since the night before. She cried for the sold motorbike, for the sentence nailed to the door, for the crooked note, for the four days, for the thirty-six years. And she understood, in the middle of the tears, with wonder, that this was not only grief: it hurt the way a rib hurts as it knits. On the inside. And healing.

10. The still hands

Whoever tells a crossing is always tempted to tell it the way the village told its floods: there was a day the water rose, there was a day it went down. It was not like that, and the book will not tell it like that. The winter that followed the crooked note was made of days, and days do not know they are a crossing: they know they are Mondays and Thursdays, soup and rain, and it was in them, one by one, that Amparo's hands went to their school.

The school had a single rule, which she discovered by trial, failing: go with him, not for him.

It sounded like little. It was a life turned the other way round.

The first lesson was at the landlady's house, in January. There was an old settling-up to be done from past works, small sums from mixed-up months, and Salvo, faced with the matter, did what he always did: he brought it to his mother, laid it on the table, and waited. And Amparo, instead of going to deal with it, said the new sentence, which still came out stiff from so little use: I'll go with you, but the one who talks is you. They went together down the river road, side by side, silent as two people go-

ing to an examination, and Amparo sat in the landlady's front room on a cane chair, hands crossed in her lap, and stayed there forty minutes without opening her mouth.

It was nearly impossible. The book must say it in so many words, because there are those who think staying silent is doing nothing: it was the most tiring thing Amparo did that month. Salvo got the dates wrong twice. He forgot a receipt she carried in her head. He accepted at first offer a figure that was arguable, let go an abatement that was his by right, and at every mistake the right words rose up Amparo's throat, ready, perfect, with thirty-six years of training, and she swallowed them one by one with the physical sensation of swallowing pins, and bit her tongue inside until it hurt. The landlady, a shrewd woman, caught on to the game halfway through and began, out of habit, talking past the son to Amparo, and Amparo then did the only thing she did in that room: she moved her eyes, slowly, to Salvo, and the landlady understood, and turned the conversation back to him.

They left with a worse agreement than she would have got. A few coins short, badly bargained, and on the way back Salvo walked tall, almost gay, redoing the conversation out loud, im-

proving it already, as one does with stories. Amparo walked doing a different sum underneath: what had been lost in money and what had been gained in man. She was not used to this currency. The exchange rate stung. But for the first time in her life she looked at a bad bargain of her son's and felt no pull to mend it, and that night she wrote in the pantry notebook, in the remarks column: today we lost a few coins. We gained I don't yet know how much. To be seen.

The laps around the square, that winter, gave Amparo something she had not expected: the village seen at the pace of a woman going nowhere. Forty years crossing the square on the diagonal, in a hurry, shop to home, home to shop, and it turned out the square, walked around, slowly, was full of people she knew by heart and had never seen. Paciência at her window, on the first floor of the corner house, always at the same hour, elbow on her little sewing cushion, watching life pass like someone expecting a delivery already thirty years late. Plácida, leaving the shop with her minimal purchases, always the exact money, always no credit, so light she could not be heard. Cordélia, on the bench by the old exchange, receiving visitors like a queen without a kingdom, for the whole village still went to tell her the news out of old habit, from the days when every

call in Véspera passed through her hands. Véspera was full of waiting women, Amparo saw, each at her window, each with her own hands. Somebody someday ought to write all their books.

And there were, that winter, the consultations. That was what Amparo called them privately, with humour, because the thing had its charm: Salvo began coming to her for advice. Not money, not rescue: advice, a coin that had never passed between them. He turned up one Saturday torn between taking an extra day at the warehouse or going to cut firewood for Glória's brother-in-law, who paid better by the day but was not steady, and he laid out the case at the table, and went quiet, waiting. And Amparo, who had the answer on the tip of her tongue, the sum done, the decision ready, wrapped and tied with string, did for once the new thing: she swallowed the answer and returned the question. And you, which way does it pull you more? And Salvo looked at her astonished, because nobody had asked him that in his life, and he thought, there, at the table, taking his time, and told the brother-in-law yes to the firewood, and it went well for him, and he never knew that his mother would have said the warehouse, and that his mother, that night, wrote in the notebook: he chose the opposite of me. And he chose. Two profits in one.

The second lesson was the warehouse one, and that one stayed in the family.

Old Justo no longer lifted loads, for the years pardon not even the upright, but the warehouse went on, his and the nephew's who ran it now, a serious man who needed someone for the loading and the winter stocktaking. Custódia knew first, of course, and sent the news along her own channels. And Salvo, pushed by the missing motorbike and by the next instalment, went, one Saturday morning, to speak to the man. Amparo went with him as far as the town, because she was going to the shop, she said, and it was a lie, and they both knew it was a lie, and they both pretended it was not, for there are lies that are scaffolding.

But she did not go into the warehouse. That was the rule, and this time it was he who set it: you wait out here, Mother. And Amparo waited.

She took one lap around the square. She bought at the shop what was not needed, under the eye of Benvinda, who said nothing and slipped into the parcel, uncharged, a honey sweet, as one does for children who are waiting. She took a second lap around the square. She stopped in front of the dry fountain and

held with it a wordless conversation, woman to stone. She took a third lap, slower, partly because her legs were no longer the legs of old but mostly because inside the warehouse a thing was being decided that she could not touch, and walking around the square was the only way her body knew of not breaking down a door. On the third lap, she realised the whole village had seen her, and that nobody had come to speak to her, and she understood what that meant: all Véspera knew what was being decided in the warehouse, and all Véspera, in its way of silent field, was giving her the room. Even the village was learning.

Salvo came out after half an hour with work for the winter. Three days a week, on trial, paid weekly. He came towards her hiding his smile under the cold, hands in his pockets, and said only, with a shrug:

"Monday at eight."

"Well then," said Amparo, looking down at her shopping bag.

"Best not be late."

"I know, Mother."

"I know you know."

And that was all. That was the entire conversation. But on the way back, on the country bus, sitting side by side watching the serra go past, Salvo fell asleep on her shoulder like a boy, defeated by relief, and Amparo kept very still, serving as his pillow, and let herself rest in it, because sustaining, she was learning, was also this: one stilled shoulder for half an hour, in silence, and nothing more. All her life she had confused sustaining with carrying. Carrying was her in front, with him on her back. Sustaining was this: side by side, he with his own weight, she simply there. The difference was the whole world.

The third lesson happened at the shop, at the end of the first warehouse month, and of that one Amparo was not a witness, and just as well, and she had it from Benvinda that same evening, with the detail and the ceremony her friend brought to great things.

Salvo had come in at the end of the afternoon, his first full week in his pocket. He had bought the usual. And at paying time, instead of paying only for the day, he had asked for the ledger. The ledger, Benvinda, he asked me for the ledger, she recounted, eyes still wide, I wiped my hands on my apron with nothing on them to wipe. And she had brought it to him, open at

his page, at the new account, the one that said payable by the holder, and Salvo had looked at his own page, at the letters of his own name, a long moment, and then had laid part of it, what he could, on the counter, and had said: cross it out where I can see it, dona Benvinda, and write what's left underneath, because I want to see it written.

"And I crossed it out, Amparo." Benvinda had the voice of a woman describing a christening. "I crossed it out before his eyes, slowly, and wrote the rest below, and he stood looking at the account the way a man looks in a mirror after a long time away. And do you know what he said to me, going out? He said: it looks handsome, the page, like this, on my account. What a thing for him to say. It looks handsome, the page."

It must also be told, because the book promised not to pretend, that the school had its failures, and that the oldest pupil failed some lessons.

There was the February envelope. The Quiet Man's big instalment fell mid-month, the warehouse wages were short of it by her reckoning, and there was a weak afternoon, for weak afternoons have their causes and the cause of this one was simple: Salvo had seemed tired to her on the Sunday. That was all. A

tired son, to a mother in training, is what an open bottle is to a man who has stopped drinking: nothing more is needed. Amparo walked all day around the image of his tiredness, and at the end of the afternoon performed the old gesture entire, deciding none of its steps: she went to the tin, counted, folded, wrote his name on the envelope, and stood with it in her hand, ready, halfway to her coat. She stood like that, in the pantry, perhaps a minute. Then she undid it all in reverse order, note by note, the way one unpicks a seam, and put the money back in the tin, and shut it, and brought the lid down harder than was needed, angry at herself, or saying goodbye, or both. The empty envelope she tore in four. To the notebook, that night, she confessed in writing: today I made an envelope. I unmade it. Next time, I don't make it. (She made two more, that winter. Unmade both. The count of unmade envelopes is also a count of victories, that's what it is.)

And there was the March lie, the last one to Vera. A small thing: her daughter asked whether the instalment had been paid on time, and it had, but three days late, negotiated by him with the Quiet Man himself, and Amparo, out of the old smoothing instinct, said paid, on time, all in order. She hung up and knew at once. She tasted it in her mouth, her mother's pitch, the wall

telephone of the house of the Olive Press. And the next morning she did what she had never in her life done: she rang back to unsay it.

"Vera. I lied to you yesterday. It was three days late, and he negotiated it himself. I lied out of habit, and I am trying to leave the habit, and with you is where it costs me most, because it was on you I used it most. There. That was it."

There was a silence on the other end, and then a strange, muffled sound, and it took Amparo a moment to understand that her daughter was laughing and crying at the same time, on the telephone, at eight in the morning.

"Mother," said Vera, when she could. "You rang me to tell me a tiresome truth one day late." And she laughed again, that wet laugh. "You have no idea what a luxury that is."

When Vera heard, on the Wednesday weekly call they kept now, about the gesture of the ledger, she was quiet a moment and then said a thing Amparo kept: do you know what that is, Mother? That is the first time in my life I have heard you correct a thing instead of hiding it. You hid everything. The accounts, the tiredness, the angers, everything under the house, and the

house always so composed on top. I grew up convinced that proper women had no wrong side. It took me thirty years to learn that they had, that you had, that your wrong side was the size of mine, only yours was not allowed to show. Keep showing me the wrong side, will you? Even a little at a time. That is the inheritance I want. The rest is payable by the holder.

The shop's sentence was travelling the whole family by then, as may be seen. Good sentences, in *Véspera*, were like the floods: nobody sent them; they reached everywhere.

The winter went passing like that, lesson by lesson, small fall by small mend. And there was a new gesture Amparo made now, discovered by chance one cold sunny morning, which became the close of her days, her ritual without a name: after the lunch things were done, when the house settled into the good silence, she drew a chair to the east window, sat down, and laid her hands open on the sill, in the sun, palms up. It was not rest, or not only. It was a new trade she was teaching them, the hardest of all the trades they had learned in sixty-three years: being. Being without holding, without counting, without folding, without catching. The hands in the sun, still, like someone setting bread to prove: without touching it, without hurry, trusting that

inside the dough, in the dark, with no help at all, something was growing of itself. The neighbour from below, who saw her like that once over the wall, asked if she was praying. Amparo thought about the answer longer than the question asked for, and then said yes, perhaps she was, in her own way: it was the only prayer she knew in which the hands could do nothing, and perhaps for that very reason, of them all, it was the one that cost her most, and the one that was worth most.

11. The rising

Spring came back, a year to the day since the landlady stood in the garden, and Véspera set up the long table in the square once more. Amparo made the usual cakes, took up the usual post, and heard, at one point in the afternoon, the contractor's wife saying to a stranger, pointing her out: that one there is a saint. The word no longer lodged in her. She heard it pass the way one hears a train in the distance, a noise from another time, bound for nowhere.

But the feast had a novelty, and the novelty got itself discreetly talked about, in the village manner: Salvo arrived early. He arrived early, hands clean from the warehouse, helped set up the tables from start to finish, and when cousin Henrique held out his hand in greeting, Salvo held it a moment longer and said something nobody heard, and put into it something everybody saw without seeing, in a three-second gesture, perfectly natural. Henrique's last money, repaid a year on, in the middle of the feast, in everyone's sight and invisible to everyone. The boy had the family's sense of ceremony; that much, at least, he had inherited straight.

And there was, at that feast, a conversation of sisters that deserves to be written down. It was Glória who came over to Amparo, in the corner of the pots, with an air between guilty and astonished at herself, and told her, half-voiced, cloth in hand: he rang me in March, you know. Desperate about the instalment, looking for someone to bail him, and it fell to me. And I said no, Amparo. I said no for the first time in my life, to someone I love. My voice shook; it felt like doing something wicked; I put the phone down and cried. And do you know what happened? And Amparo said she knew, but let her say it, because Glória needed to say it: nothing happened. That is what happened: nothing. He didn't die, he didn't disappear, he didn't stop speaking to me. The Sunday after, he turned up at my house helping your brother-in-law with the firewood as if nothing had been. All my life I was afraid of the no, Amparo. If only I'd known the no has nothing in it.

Salvo's year was not a miracle, and the book takes its leave here of anyone still hoping for one. It was a thing far rarer: it was an ordinary year.

He worked the whole winter at the warehouse, three days a week, then four. He came late twice and heard from old Justo's nephew what one hears at work when one comes late, and did not quit over it, nor fall ill, nor bring the offence to his mother's table: he swallowed it, as everyone swallows theirs, and set his alarm earlier. He paid the Quiet Man's instalments, one by one, nearly always on time. He went on paying down the shop account, in plain sight, the page handsomer and handsomer, in his own expression, which Benvinda adopted and now used on her whole clientele: well now, this page of yours, shall we beautify it?

And he failed one. The book tells this one too, because in it the rest can be seen.

It was in April. Adelino, the workmate of the rent from a year before, was in need again, this time over a sick child, and Salvo, being the son of who he was and the grandson of who he was, did what his blood told him: he gave what he had, and what he had was the Quiet Man's instalment. The story reached Amparo by the usual road, before the deadline, and for two days she went about with her heart in her mouth and her hands on the windowsill, waiting for the telephone, for the knock at the door,

for the bare and trembling Mother. She made herself ready for it the way one makes ready for a flood: sandbags at the door, everything stacked high.

The asking did not come.

What came, she learned afterwards, in pieces, from Benvinda and from Custódia, was this: Salvo went to the warehouse and asked old Justo's nephew for two weeks' advance, and the man, who was coming to know him, asked what it was for, and Salvo, instead of the dressed-up story he was capable of, gave it to him dry: I gave my debt money to a friend in trouble, I did my own accounts harm because I don't know how to say no, and I would rather owe you, who can dock it from my work, than fail my word in the big town. The man gave him the advance. And told him, according to the version that ran the village, a sentence that was better than money: your fault has a mend to it, lad. The other way round would be worse; of that sickness of giving too much nobody ever died who hadn't first died of giving nothing.

Amparo heard the full account in the back room of the shop, the blow-strength coffee in front of her, and when it ended she sat quiet, looking into her cup.

"He solved it badly," said Benvinda, playing devil's advocate by the office of friendship. "There he is owing two to pay one."

"He solved it badly," Amparo agreed. And she lifted her face, and Benvinda saw in her eyes a new thing, which took a moment to name because she had never seen it there unmixed: rest. "He solved it badly, alone, at his own cost, inside his own size. Benvinda: my son had money trouble, and I learned of it from the village, like the other mothers. A year ago, this was a sleepless night of mine and an emptier tin. This year it was a conversation between him and his employer. Call it what you like. I know by now the name it has."

"Which is?"

"A man living his own life." And she smiled, slowly, inward. "It took me sixty-three years to see one. Such a common thing, and how well hidden they kept it."

There was as well, that spring, a new rhythm to the Sundays, which had made itself, with nobody arranging it: Salvo came at the end of the morning, but he no longer came as before, hands swinging and appetite ready. He brought things. Small, crooked, his: a cheese from the big town, split firewood left over from a

day's wage, once a bunch of flowers bought from the old woman at the market, which he handed his mother with the embarrassment of a boy of twelve and which left her speechless at the sink, back turned, longer than the jar needed finding. It was not the account being squared; that could not be and was not the point. It was another thing, more important than the account: it was a man learning, by feel, late, with errors of measure, the gesture they had never let him make, that of arriving at a house with full hands instead of empty ones. Amparo received it all. That was her share of the work, and she discovered its cost: to receive the crooked cheese and not say you shouldn't have, to receive the flowers and not ask what they cost, to receive, simply, the way one lets the other exist in the giving. The house's two lessons were one lesson after all, seen from opposite sides.

It was in that spring, with her son rising badly and slowly and by his own strength, that the other thing happened, the one Amparo was not expecting, because she had spent her life watching the side the falls came from, and the other child, the one who never fell, had never given her the trouble of watching for her.

Vera rang on a Wednesday night, outside her hours, for Vera had hours as she had everything. And her voice came strange, came short of numbered points.

"Mother. Could I come and sleep there one night? Friday, say." A pause that was not a stitch; it was herself being stitched. "Joaquim will keep the boy. Nothing's wrong, everything's fine, it's only that..." And then Amparo's eldest, forty years old, married, certain, the family's straight column, said the sentence she had taken a whole life to be able to say: "I want to come just me. Me. I'm not bringing anything, not sorting anything, not coming to fix anything. I just wanted to come, Mother. Can I?"

"You can," said Amparo, and said no more, because her voice would not carry more, and because a year had taught her that some doors open wider on fewer words.

Vera arrived Friday at the end of the afternoon with a small bag and the air of a girl playing truant. And the two women's evening was a thing neither of them knew how to do, and they did it anyway, feeling their way: nothing. Soup, bread, wine from the visitors' bottle which it turned out was also for daughters. The dishes stayed unwashed till morning, by express and revolutionary decision of the lady of the house. And at the table, with

the night coming down slowly outside, with retreats, with laughter in between, with silences that no longer frightened either of them, came all the conversations that had waited forty years for their turn.

The corner of the table came. Vera told it from her side, and Amparo listened without defending herself, which was the only way that listening could be done: the girl of four at the opposite corner, learning to eat without spilling, to be ill without fever. The certainty, grown into her like a bone, that love in that house was a short blanket, and that for its shortness nobody was to blame, but that pulling it towards herself was theft, because at the other end there was always someone shivering colder. I decided not to need, Mother; it was my way of helping you; you never knew it but I worked for you my whole life: my work was giving no trouble. And then I married, and went off to give no trouble in another house, and I have a good husband and a good life and for forty years nobody has asked me whether I need anything, because I built a woman of whom it isn't asked. I built her too well. Some days I can't find her door myself.

And the story of the prize came, which Amparo did not know, and which hurt her more than all the others together for being so small. Vera was twelve and won the school prize, the one from the big-town competition, the first anyone from Véspera had won. She ran the whole road home with the certificate in her hand, rehearsed at the door the way she would tell it, and when she came into the kitchen Salvo had fallen out of the landlady's fig tree, nothing grave, a twisted wrist, but the house was in a state of cord, her mother boiling cloths, her father on the way to the doctor's, and Vera stood in the middle of the kitchen with the certificate in her hand, waiting her turn, and the turn did not come that day, nor the next, and by the third day she herself had already put the certificate away in a drawer and the hope away in the place where hopes that embarrass us are kept. She never showed it again. It's still at home, Mother, said Vera at the table, forty years on. It has moved house with me four times, always in the bottom drawer. I no longer even know what I expect to happen when I open it. I think I expect it to still be waiting for me.

And the other side came, which Vera did not know: the promise to the purple newborn, the year of the hand on his chest, the fear with its roots in the house of the Olive Press, Faustino,

Amadeu, the three books open on the Keeper's desk. Amparo told it all, and told at last, because her daughter had a right to her, the sentence of the washing tank: do you think Mother helped him, or do you think Mother finished him? And Vera, hearing it, closed her eyes.

"And you," said Amparo, and reached her hand across the table, across the crumbs, and laid it on her daughter's, "you I finished the other way round, didn't I? Him I gave too much lap, you I gave too little. I had two children and got the sum wrong in both, each to opposite sides." She pressed her hand, slowly. "You asked me for nothing your whole life, daughter. And I allowed it. It was so restful, your side. Forgive me the rest I made out of your loneliness."

Vera did not answer in words. She turned her hand over, palm up, inside her mother's hand, and the fingers of the two of them closed together, and they stayed like that, hands held on the table among the unwashed dishes, the two most capable women of Véspera, defeated at last in the good direction, and from the kitchen clock came that sound clocks make when nobody is speaking, which is no tick-tock at all; it is time, stitching.

In the morning, Amparo woke first, as always. She made the coffee, and when her daughter appeared in the kitchen, tousled and new, the pillow's crease on her cheek, the mother did not let her lay the table or lift a thing. But at the garden door, in the sun, cup in hand, she made her a request. It was premeditated: she had rehearsed it the night before, before sleeping, because she knew that to the daughter who never asked, the greatest present was not to give to her. It was to ask of her.

"Before you go, will you help me pull the broad beans? It's two hours on the knees, and I no longer have them for it alone. And you always did have a better hand for beans than your brother. Don't say no, for it's true."

Vera looked at her mother over the cup, and understood everything, of course, because Vera always understood everything; that was her cross and her crown. She understood, and accepted the new coin of that house at its face value.

"Lend me some old trousers," she said.

And they spent the morning the two of them on their knees in the earth, side by side, pulling beans and talking of nothing, and anyone passing on the road who looked over the wall would

have seen only that, two women in a garden in April, and would have seen nothing, and would have seen it all: because it was exactly like that, kneeling in the same furrow, at the same height as one another, neither one carrying the other, that the two of them had gone a whole life without ever managing to be.

12. The winter

Winter returned to Véspera in the usual order: first to the serra, then to the river, last of all to the people. It was a year now since the morning at the shop, since the money folded in four in the coat pocket, since the first question. And in Amparo's house, in that new year of cold, there was a change so small that nobody from outside would have noticed it, and which for her was the measure of everything: the hands no longer woke before she did.

They woke with her. She opened her eyes in the dark and the hands waited, resting on the bedspread, patient as old dogs that no longer run to the door at the first sound, and it was she who decided, now, where the day began. It almost always began with the same things: the fire, the water, the soup. Amparo's life, seen from outside, was exactly the life it had always been. The whole revolution had happened in a place where there are no neighbours: in the order of who commands.

The year's fall came in December, the week before the winter feast, and it came the way falls came now: on its own feet.

Salvo appeared on a Thursday night with the cold clinging to his coat, and she knew at first sight, of course. That she would never unlearn, nor wished to: a mother reads her son at the door the way the Keeper reads the records; it is her oldest alphabet. The warehouse work was stopping two weeks over the feast days, unpaid, and the Quiet Man's January instalment was left uncovered, and there was the firewood besides, and the rent, and he brought all the sums in his head and the discouragement trying to settle down on top of them.

He sat at the table. And here the book asks that a thing be noticed which nobody in the kitchen remarked on, because the great things of houses are never remarked on: Salvo did not sit in the corner. He drew out the chair beside hers, the one that had been his father's, and sat there, facing the window, and the corner of the table stood empty with its three generations of shadow inside it, and neither of them looked at it, and both of them knew.

Amparo set the soup in front of him. That was hers, would be hers to the end, and she had made her peace with it: to feed the people one loves is not to carry anyone; it is love's oldest trade.

And then she sat down opposite her son, hands quiet around her own bowl, and did what a year of school had taught her to do in place of everything she used to do.

She listened. To the end, advancing no solutions midway, doing none of his sums aloud, letting his silences finish on their own, for it was in the silences that Salvo did his thinking, she had discovered, and all his life she had filled them up with rescue.

And when he finished, she asked:

"And what have you thought of doing?"

It was not the question of the first winter, the one that fell into the kitchen like a stone into still water. It was the same question one year on, worn with use, domestic, and Salvo answered it without raising his guard, because the question no longer accused; it only asked. He had thought of going to the Quiet Man before the deadline, face to face, for the man valued those who came ahead of time, and asking to split January across February and March; and there was the firewood at Glória's brother-in-law's, who needed arms for the splitting and paid for the favour;

and maybe, Mother, maybe he'd finally sell the old sound system, which only gathered dust now and was still worth something in the big town.

"You see?" said Amparo. "You brought the problem and you brought three pieces of the answer. A year ago you brought only the problem, and carried the answer away from here, made by me, wrapped like cake." She pushed the bread towards him. "Go and talk to the Quiet Man. It's what I would do first."

"You're not going to offer me anything?" he asked, and it was no longer any kind of asking: it was astonishment making a joke of itself, it was almost pride, it was a man measuring, with his mother, the road the two of them had walked.

"I am," she said. "Soup tonight, and you'll take half of tomorrow's baking, and the new blanket I made, for that house of yours by the river is cold." She looked at him over the bowl, and there was laughter in her eyes, the good kind. "The rest is payable by the holder."

The shop's phrase made him laugh out loud, and his laughter filled the kitchen, Fortunato's easy laugh, and this time it was not shield nor blade nor coin: it was only laughter. And mother

and son had their supper together, one more Thursday of winter, talking of the feast, of Vera coming Saturday with the boy, of the weather, of the small immense things families talk of when nobody is drowning.

Salvo went to the big town the next day to speak to the Quiet Man before the deadline, and the conversation went as he had thought it would, and was known in Véspera down to the detail, like everything: that the man of the still hands received him, heard the proposal of splitting January over the following months, looked at him a longish moment, and said yes; and that at the door he added, in the tone of a man giving no weight at all to what he says, a sentence Salvo carried home like a certificate: last year your mother came here for you. This year you come before the day. Next year you won't need to come at all, for a man who comes early twice has credit in any market. Tell your mother she is released of her word. You are worth your own now.

The next day, making the promised bread, Amparo opened the pantry and stood a moment, as she always stood now, looking at the high shelf.

And there was one thing more in the pantry, beside the tin, that deserves the record: the tin of nails had disappeared. It had gone one Saturday in autumn, in a clearing-out, when Amparo came upon it at the back of the shelf with its thirty-odd years of dust and its half kilo of shame inside, and instead of wiping it and putting it back in its place, as she had done in every clearing-out of a lifetime, she carried it downstairs and emptied it into the toolbox, where nails should always have been. They got used, what is more. Salvo went through nearly all of them one Sunday, mending the henhouse, with no idea in the world of what he was hammering in, and perhaps that is why the henhouse came out so well mended: there are materials that wait decades for their right work.

Now, every time she opened the pantry, the flour tin stood there with the seeds inside, waiting for March. The change had been made in October, in a gesture she had not planned. She had gone with Salvo to the big town on an instalment day; had waited at the door of the café by the old station, on the pavement, for what went on inside was his; and at the market alongside, while she waited, she had bought, on an impulse, from an old woman crying her wares in a cracked voice, half a dozen little paper packets: seeds. Cabbage, lettuce, onion, and some

flowers whose name she didn't know, bought only because the woman said they bore the frost well. At home, that afternoon, she had taken from the tin the money that remained, little, and moved it to the drawer of the chest, into the light, next to the record folded in four, where a house's money ought to live: to hand, without secrecy, without shrine. And into the tin, into the old flour tin that held no flour, into the hiding place of thirty-six years of fear, she had put the little paper packets.

It was foolishness, she knew. Nobody keeps seeds in a tin like that. But Amparo had learned something from the library of gestures that a life is, and she knew that houses are healed through the inside of their objects too, and she wanted it so: that the deepest place in the house, the vault of the old fear, should keep things that know how to do one thing only, which is grow up out of the earth, unlike everything that had been kept there before, which only knew how to cover falls.

On the eve of the winter feast, Amparo crossed the square and climbed the three steps of the House of Records.

The Keeper was at her desk, as always, as if she had not left it since the spring, and perhaps she had not. She looked up and showed no surprise, surprise not being the trade of that house.

"Dona Amparo. The papers were all settled, if I remember rightly."

"They were." Amparo took from her coat pocket the paper folded in four. It was more worn than it should have been, from a year of living on the chest of drawers and being opened more times than she would have admitted aloud. She laid it on the desk and pushed it half a hand's width across, in the manner of that land. "I've come to bring this, to stay with the papers of the house. When one day they come to settle my affairs, I want it to be there among them. The deed, the partitions, the powers of attorney, and this."

The Keeper looked at the paper without touching it.

"It's a copy, dona Amparo. The true record is in the book; it cannot be lost."

"I know. That's not why." Amparo felt for the words slowly, because she had thought them out on the way over, but thinking and saying are different trades. "The papers of the house say what I owned and who it goes to. They are correct, and they were needed. But I have spent this year learning something and I want to leave it written my own way, and my own way is this. I

want whoever opens the folder of my papers one day to find this one first. Let it be known that before the house, and the garden, and the accounts, and all the others, there was a person here. She began here. Her name was Amparo. She was born in the year of the Great Winter, with the whole of life still to write. And she wrote some of it, in the end. Better late."

The Keeper took up the paper then, with that care of hers for living things, and rose, and opened the deep cupboard where the folders of the houses of Véspera slept, and before her eyes, unhurried, she filed the copy of Amparo's birth record on top of all the other papers in the folder of the house, right on top, so that it would be, beyond any doubt, the first thing.

"It goes first," she said, closing the cupboard. And then, turning, she did what in four generations few people of Véspera had seen: she smiled. It was little, it was brief, but it was. "You are the third person, in all my years, to come and put themselves into the papers of their own house. I told you in the spring that the other two changed their lives. I lied by shortfall. They did not change their lives. They changed their place inside them. The life was the same. It was they who began to be in it."

Amparo went down the three steps into the square, and the square was at its December best: the clean cold, the chimney smoke all standing straight, the men setting up the tables for the next day's feast, the dry fountain pale stone, and beyond the rooftops the serra with the first white of the year. She stood a moment at the top of the steps, looking at the whole village, and caught herself doing a thing she had not done in a long time: nothing. She was not ahead of schedule for anything. Nobody needed her within the hour. The world, astonishingly, went on working.

The winter feast was held the next day, as it had been held since before memory: the long table set up in the old hall of the Mill, where in the cold the village ate indoors, under the high beams, among the stopped and shrouded machines that nobody had the heart to sell. And at the table of that feast, that year, there was a piece of afternoon that Amparo kept entire, the way one keeps a photograph nobody took: the whole family along one stretch of the table, nobody missing. Custódia and Glória arguing over the roast as they had for sixty years. Vera with the boy beside her, and the boy, who was at the age of questions, pulling at his grandmother: and when you were little, granny, what did you have? And she answering him with stories of the Great

Winter which Custódia corrected from across the table, for the sentinel let no date pass even at a feast. Joaquim and Salvo in the men's talk, of works and of firewood. And at one point the boy, loud and clear as boys speak, pointed at Salvo and asked his mother: does uncle live with us now? And there came one of those half-seconds, and Salvo laughed first of everyone and answered it himself: no, man. Uncle lives with uncle now. And it was a joke, and they all laughed, and under the joke there passed along the table, woman to woman, from Custódia to Vera to Amparo, a look that needed no words, because the three of them knew the size of what the boy had just been told in play.

At home, at the end of the next afternoon, she sat at the east window, in the ritual chair, though there was no longer sun on the sill, for in December the sun takes its leave early. She sat there all the same, for the pleasure of it, the blanket on her knees, and laid her hands in her lap, one inside the other, palms upward.

Without meaning to, she took the year's inventory by way of the hands, which was the only bookkeeping in which she never erred. These hands had paid off a whole ledger for the last time. They had signed a schedule at midnight in the big town and had

taken their leave of a sleeping chest. They had sat still in a front-room lap while a man got his dates wrong and grew. They had made three envelopes and unmade three envelopes. They had pulled broad beans kneeling beside her daughter's, which were like them, only newer and less worn, and still in time to learn it earlier. They had emptied a tin of old nails into the box where they should always have been. And they had received flowers, a crooked cheese, a blanket's worth of thanks, giving nothing back, which had been, of all the year's labours, the hardest and the finest.

She looked at them, as on that night a year before, at the table, in her son's place. The same hands: the ring sunk into the finger, the olive-press scar, the thick knuckles, and one year more, for at sixty-four the years are counted in hands as in tree trunks. They were still. Not with the beaten stillness of things that have given up, for that stillness Amparo knew from other old women of the village, hands laid down like empty gloves. It was another stillness, and she knew its name now; it had taken her a year to learn it: it was the stillness of trust. The still hands of a woman who knows that her son, at this hour, is in his own house by the river, with the new blanket, doing his own sums with his own mistakes and his own strength; that her daughter comes on

Saturday and will ask, when she needs to, because she has learned the door; that the soup will stretch to everyone and the bread is promised; and that the world, with all its load of possible falls, can get through one night, this night, with nobody on watch.

Outside, far off, the river Fundo went its way in the dark, full with the rains, gentle and mighty, doing what rivers do.

And that is how the year ended in which the house changed weight: with no miracle at all, in a chair by a window, with a woman's hands open in her lap, waiting for the winter and the feast and whatever should come, settled at last in her own life like the seed in the tin: inside the old vault of fear, whole, alive, waiting for March.

From the register of Véspera

*In the record of the house of the Olive Press, in the Keeper's hand,
this was further written, outside the ruled lines, in the corner
where Keepers write what has no column:*

*This year nobody was born in this house, nobody married, no-
body departed. Whoever searches the books will find nothing.*

*But there are years in which a house changes weight, and that the
records cannot say. It is known to whoever weighs the folders in
the cupboard, as I do. This house's grew lighter this year, and
nothing was taken out of it. Rather the contrary: a small paper
went in, folded in four, in first place.*

*The records say who was born, who married, who departed. They
do not say who carries whom. But when a woman comes to put
herself into the papers of her own house, at sixty-four, with her
hands still, I make my record in my own way, in this corner:
Amparo, of the house of the Olive Press, born in the year of the
Great Winter, arrived this year at her own life.*

*The road was longer for her than for those who come from far
away. She was coming from nearer. It is always, in my books, the
longest journey there is.*

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